
North Lake

Waukesha County · WBIC 850800 · 440 acres · 78.4 ft

This lake-specific assembled library uses the same black-and-white loose PDFs published on the project page. Individually confirmed species, candidate members of the DNR's broad "panfish" record, and historical material occupy separate modules. A candidate sheet helps identify and prepare a catch; it does not claim that the named panfish is present.

Rules are dated 2026–27. Before every trip, check Wisconsin DNR's live rules and consumption query for this exact water, species, length, and date. Printed text never overrides the current rule.

What is bound

I. Lake	Independent bathymetric line map, access context, evidence limits, and dated rules for North Lake.
II. Fish + kitchen	Confirmed fish first, then a clearly divided candidate panfish module; each field sheet is followed by its cooking guide.
III. Rigs	Eleven retained rig sheets, each useful for at least one supported fish group or seasonal presentation on this water.
IV. Reference	Reading water, lures and bait, calendar, knots, handling and release, and first-trip workflow.

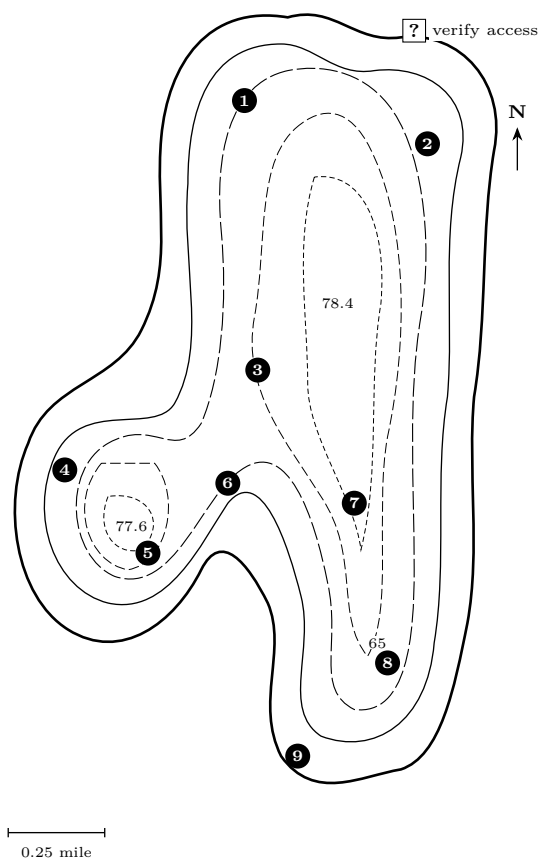
Evidence boundary
The current DNR record individually names largemouth bass, smallmouth bass, northern pike, and walleye, and broadly names panfish. Five named panfish appear only in a separate candidate module because the group record cannot establish individual presence. Cisco and muskellunge are not bound: a regulation is not presence evidence, and no authoritative current North Lake record supporting either was found.

I The lake

Read this first. The map is an independently reconstructed fishing aid, not a navigation chart; verify access, weather, water level, hazards, and posted ordinances at departure.

North is a deep drainage lake with two strongly defined basins joined through a narrow structural corridor. The historical survey shows abrupt edges, small humps and a south neck toward Mud Lake. Use those shapes as hypotheses; confirm today’s depth, vegetation, access and hazards yourself.

Identity	WBIC 850800; 440 acres
Depth	78.4 ft maximum
Bottom	50% sand; 30% gravel; 20% muck
Type	Drainage lake; DNR classifies it eutrophic
Current DNR fish record	Panfish, largemouth bass, smallmouth bass, northern pike and walleye
Access	DNR does not list a numbered landing on the facts page. Confirm legal public access before arrival; a historical road is not permission



Generalized depth contours: solid 10 ft; widely dashed 20 ft; long dash 40 ft; short dash 60 ft; labeled historical soundings. **Not for navigation.** Independently drafted from the Wisconsin Conservation Department sheet compiled in 1898 and revised in 1941; current shoreline/access context checked against 2024 USDA/FSA NAIP aerial orthophotography. No imagery is reproduced. A question mark means access must be independently verified.

Nine places to test, not promises

#	Area	Why test it	First pass
1	North flat	Broad shallow water meets the main basin.	Search for the current weed edge and bait; cover it without crossing beds.
2	Northeast break	Contours crowd the eastern shore.	Keep the boat outside, cast uphill, and identify contact depth.
3	Central channel edge	A structural corridor joins north and south water.	Scan both lips for bait or fish before committing.
4	West-lobe rim	A sharp outside curve enters the western basin.	Work from the shallow crown down through 20–40 ft.
5	West-lobe basin	A compact 77.6-ft bowl offers nearby deep water.	Scan for suspended life; do not fish empty depth.
6	Central saddle	The pinch between lobes concentrates routes, not necessarily fish.	Make controlled passes on each side and compare.
7	Southeast hump	Small isolated structure breaks the main basin wall.	Circle it to find the steep and windward faces.
8	South basin edge	A 65-ft pocket meets the lower taper.	Check low light and seasonal transitions; follow bait, not the printed number.
9	South neck	Shallow constriction toward Mud Lake.	Verify navigation, access and regulations before fishing moving-water edges.

North Lake sequence

1. Confirm legal public access before towing or carrying a craft to the water. Read every posted ordinance and high-water notice.
2. Sample one lobe, the saddle and one eastern break. A lake-wide pattern needs repeated depth/bottom evidence, not one bite.
3. Because DNR classifies North as eutrophic, let current vegetation, oxygen, clarity and bait observations override the antique contour sheet.
4. DNR records Eurasian water-milfoil and zebra mussel. Inspect, remove and drain before transport; never move live fish away from the water.

ACCESS AND CONTOURS REQUIRE VERIFICATION

The source map began in 1898 and was revised in 1941. Its north road label does not establish a present public landing. Neither this redrawing nor an aerial image grants access. Confirm ownership, legal access, depth and hazards through current official information and direct observation.

2026–27 rules printed for departure planning

Bass	Harvest May 2, 2026–Mar. 7, 2027; 14 in minimum; 5 daily. Catch-and-release is open year-round unless otherwise noted.
Northern pike	May 2, 2026–Mar. 7, 2027; 26 in minimum; 2 daily.
Walleye group	May 2, 2026–Mar. 7, 2027; 18 in minimum; 3 daily.
Panfish	Open all year; no minimum; 25 daily.
Rock/yellow/white bass	Open all year; no minimum; unlimited.
Cisco/whitefish	Open all year; no minimum; 10 daily. Category does not prove presence.
Muskellunge	May 2–Dec. 31, 2026, open water only; 40 in minimum; 1 daily. Category does not prove presence.
Motor trolling	Allowed with up to 3 hooks, baits or lures per angler.

RECHECK BEFORE EVERY TRIP

These are the Wisconsin DNR lookup results for WBIC 850800 checked 26 July 2026. Verify the exact water, species and date in the live DNR rules. The DNR says listed regulation categories may not reflect fish actually present. Posted signs are the definitive practical check for slow-no-wake areas/hours, high-water restrictions and other local ordinances because the database may lag.

Evidence boundary

The current DNR lake record supports panfish, largemouth bass, smallmouth bass, northern pike and walleye. It does not resolve “panfish” into individual species. Do not treat regulation-only categories as an inventory. The provider-neutral evidence record is `research/lake-country-fishing/lakes-north.md`.

Primary sources

Wisconsin DNR Lake Page and historical contour sheet (WBIC 850800); Wisconsin DNR exact-water fishing-regulation lookup (checked 2026-07-26); Wisconsin DNR 2026–27 regulation changes; USDA/FSA 2024 NAIP via the Wisconsin statewide imagery service. Full URLs and limitations are in the research file.

Telos. Lake Country Fishing — North Lake. Revised 2026-07-26. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See `LICENSE` and `CREDITS.md` in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.

II Confirmed fish and kitchen

Field identification and tactics are paired with complete harvest preparation. Named panfish are excluded because a broad group record does not establish individual presence. A legal fish is not automatically the preferred fish to keep.

Largemouth Bass

Cover-oriented predator with a jaw past the eye

Micropterus salmoides

Recognize it

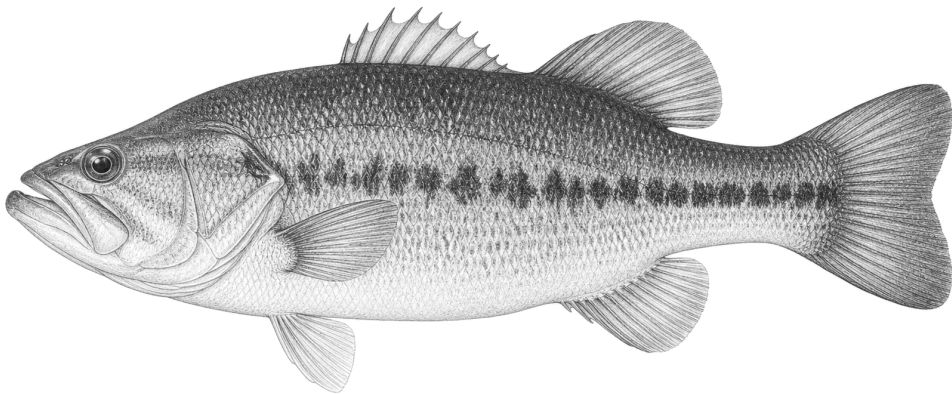
Green bass with dark lateral band; closed jaw extends beyond rear of eye.

Body	Deep-bodied; first and second dorsal sections separated by a deep notch.
Mouth/fins	Very large mouth; tongue lacks a tooth patch.
Confusion	Smallmouth jaw ends near mid-eye and usually shows vertical bars.

Lake role

Where it belongs
Vegetation, wood, docks, shade, and nearby depth.
Food and season
Fish, crayfish, and large invertebrates; shallow around warming cover, deeper or shaded in heat.

Identification plate



Original graphite portrait for this ChatGPT edition. Morphology reviewed against Wisconsin DNR species references.

Find it on these waters

Pine	Test protected vegetation and shade, then the deep edge in clear midday conditions.
North	Test weed flats, wood, narrows, and current-adjacent ambush edges.
Evidence	The DNR lake records sometimes name only a broad group such as panfish. In that case this species is a candidate member, not verified individual presence. Confirm presence before targeting; treat locations as testable habitat hypotheses, not abundance findings.

Presentations

1. **Weightless plastic.** Skip or pitch to holes and shade; let it fall on slack line and watch for movement.
2. **Texas rig.** Probe dense cover with enough weight for bottom contact, not more.
3. **Stop rule.** After several accurate casts without evidence, change cover type or depth before changing lure details.

HANDLING DECIDES THE OUTCOME

Land promptly, wet hands, support larger fish horizontally, and never hang a heavy fish by the jaw.

Water-specific rule	May 2, 2026–Mar 7, 2027; 14-in minimum; bass daily bag 5 combined on both lakes.
Kitchen choice	If harvested, favor a legal mid-size fish over a scarce trophy; larger adults are valuable spawners.
Before the trip	Open the Wisconsin DNR water-specific regulation page for WBIC 779200 (Pine) or 850800 (North). Check the exact water, species, and date; the live rule controls if this dated sheet differs.

Keep only a fish you can use

Decide before the cast. Bring ice, stop fishing when the planned meal is secured, and use the species-specific cooking guide for dispatch, bone layout, and safe preparation. Large old predators are valuable spawners and generally carry more mercury than smaller fish.

Sources checked 2026-07-26. Wisconsin DNR lake fish records (Pine WBIC 779200; North WBIC 850800), Wisconsin’s Fishes, Hook Your Catch, 2026–27 water-specific regulations, Catch-and-release Guidelines, and Eating Your Catch. Biological and tactical synthesis is editorial; it is not a current population survey.

Telos. Lake Country Fishing · ChatGPT — Largemouth Bass. Revised 2026-07-26. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See LICENSE and CREDITS.md in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.

Cooking Largemouth Bass

Micropterus salmoides · kitchen guide

From legal fish to boneless meal

START WITH A LAWFUL, COLD FISH

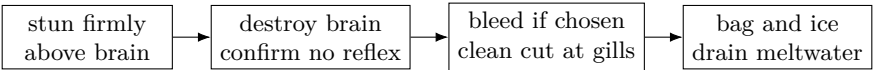
Confirm the live Wisconsin DNR rule and consumption advisory for the exact water, species, length, and date. Kill a retained fish promptly; do not let it suffocate slowly. Bleed only where lawful and practical, then place it in a draining ice slurry or on ice. Keep raw fish at or below 40 °F; wash hands, knife, and board after contact with viscera.

Keep or release?

Legal floor	May 2, 2026–Mar 7, 2027; 14-in minimum; bass daily bag 5 combined on both lakes.
Preferred table fish	A legal lower- to mid-size fish; release large adults.
Why	Smaller legal bass portions are milder and large fish contribute disproportionately to spawning and can carry more mercury.

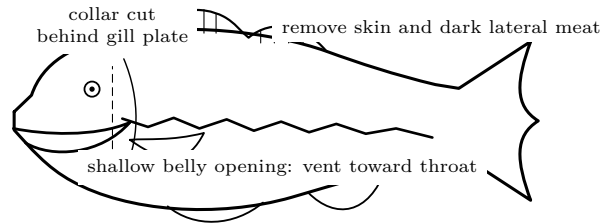
Legal is not the same as desirable. A fish may be lawful yet a poor choice because it is a large breeder, exceeds current meal advice, or cannot be chilled and used promptly.

Dispatch and field care



1. Use a decisive percussive blow to the skull immediately above and just behind the eyes. Follow with a spike or narrow knife into the brain cavity.
2. Confirm loss of rhythmic gill movement and eye reflex. If either remains, repeat immediately. Cut the gill arches only after insensibility.
3. Keep the fish shaded, clean, and cold. Do not soak flesh in warm lake water. At home, work in small batches and return finished portions to ice.

Clean without contaminating the flesh



1. **Set up.** Flexible sharp fillet knife, cut-resistant glove on the non-knife hand, scaler or spoon if needed, pliers, clean towels, two trays.
2. **Scale or skin.** For skinless fillets, do not scale. Fillet first, lay skin down, and slide the blade between skin and flesh. Trim the dark lateral strip and belly fat.
3. **Open shallowly.** From vent toward the throat, lift the belly wall away from organs and use the tip only. Remove viscera intact. Avoid puncturing the gall bladder; trim and rinse any contaminated tissue.
4. **Kidney line.** Scrape the dark tissue along the backbone and rinse briefly with clean potable water. Pat dry. Never use soap on food.

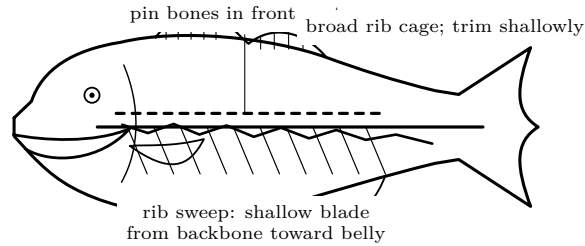
Parasites and raw fish

Freezing and pickling are not substitutes for a validated parasite-control process. Cook wild freshwater fish to an internal temperature of 145 °F, or until opaque and separating easily, unless following a qualified food-safety process. Discard abnormal-smelling or badly diseased flesh; when uncertain, do not eat it.

Species-specific first cuts

Cut behind the gill plate around the shoulder, turn at backbone, and run to tail. Lift the fillet and sweep over broad ribs; avoid opening the gut cavity with the knife tip.

Bone map and deboning



1. Keep the skin side down so the blade can ride on, not through, the bones.
2. Remove the rib cage with a shallow sweep, sacrificing as little belly meat as possible. Run fingertips both directions along every cut surface.
3. Locate pins by brushing head-to-tail and back. Pull firm bones or V-cut the centerline ahead of the point where pins disappear.
4. Portion only after a final fingertip inspection under a bright light. Bones become harder to locate once batter, crumbs, or sauce is added.

Trim map
Remove skin, rib membrane, belly fat, and dark lateral tissue. These trims reduce stronger flavor and some fat-associated contaminants, but do not remove mercury.

Prepare before heat

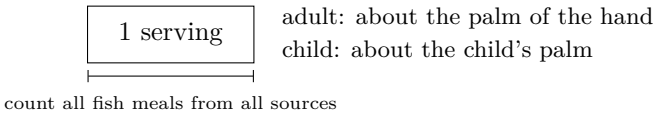
- Pat portions dry. Equal thickness matters more than equal weight.
- Cut thick shoulder and thin tail into separate portions. A brief milk soak changes flavor but does not make unsafe fish safe.
- Refrigerate while the pan, oven, or grill heats. Marinate under refrigeration; discard marinade that contacted raw fish unless boiled.

Two dependable methods

Black-pepper skillet bass
Sear dry, lightly oiled portions; lower heat after browning and finish to 145 °F without repeatedly turning.
Tomato-herb baked bass
Bake equal-thickness portions under a thin tomato-herb layer; verify 145 °F in the shoulder.

Current safe-eating advice · checked 2026-07-26

Statewide inland baseline for bass: women under 50 and children under 15, up to one serving/month; women 50+ and men, up to one/week. Lake-specific advice and length can be stricter.



THE QUERY BEATS THE PRINTED SHEET

Wisconsin has a statewide inland baseline and water-specific exceptions. Before eating, use DNR’s Fish Consumption Advisory Query for Pine Lake (WBIC 779200) or North Lake (WBIC 850800), and match species and length. People who are pregnant, may become pregnant, are breastfeeding, and children need the more protective category. When advice changes, follow the current query.

Sources. Wisconsin DNR Eating Your Catch and 2026–27 water-specific regulations; Wisconsin DHS Eat Fish Safely; USDA/FoodSafety.gov Safe Minimum Internal Temperature Chart; University of Minnesota Extension, Preserving Food at Home: Meat, Fish and Poultry. Cleaning sequence and monochrome diagrams are original editorial synthesis, checked 2026-07-26.

Telos. Lake Country Fishing · ChatGPT — Cooking Largemouth Bass. Revised 2026-07-26. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See LICENSE and CREDITS.md in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.

Recognize it

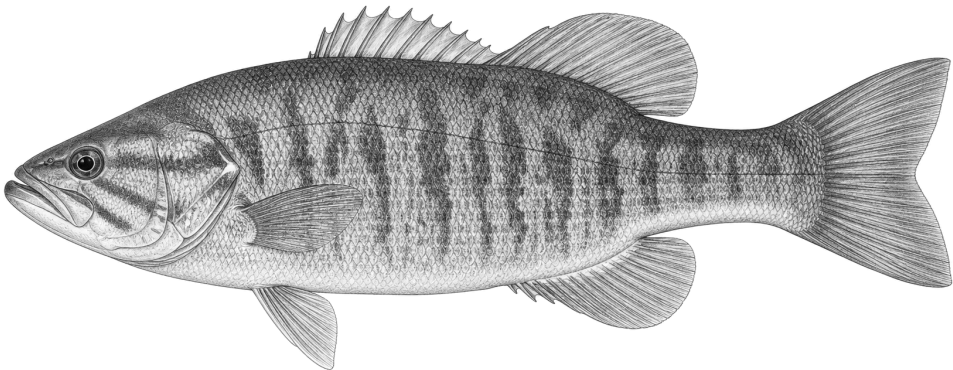
Bronze bass with vertical side bars; closed jaw does not extend beyond rear of eye.

Body	Elongate; dorsal sections connected with a shallow notch.
Mouth/fins	Large mouth smaller than largemouth's; tongue may have tooth patch.
Confusion	Largemouth is greener, has a strong horizontal band, and jaw extends past eye.

Lake role

Where it belongs
Rock, gravel, points, breaks, and crayfish-rich transitions.
Food and season
Crayfish and fish; shifts from warming shallows to deeper hard edges and fall prey routes.

Identification plate



Original graphite portrait for this ChatGPT edition. Morphology reviewed against Wisconsin DNR species references.

Find it on these waters

Pine North Evidence	Test gravel points and steep hard breaks; in clear water use long casts and natural depth control. Test rocky narrows, points, and firm patches beside vegetation or current. The DNR lake records sometimes name only a broad group such as panfish. In that case this species is a candidate member, not verified individual presence. Confirm presence before targeting; treat locations as testable habitat hypotheses, not abundance findings.
---------------------	---

Presentations

- 1. **Tube or Ned rig.** Drag or short-hop across rock while maintaining bottom contact.
- 2. **Drop shot.** Hold a small bait above bottom when fish are marked but inactive.
- 3. **Stop rule.** Change casting angle before lure; if no hard bottom or prey evidence appears, relocate.

HANDLING DECIDES THE OUTCOME

Land promptly, wet hands, support large fish level, and reduce air exposure in warm water.

Water-specific rule	May 2, 2026–Mar 7, 2027; 14-in minimum; bass daily bag 5 combined on both lakes.
Kitchen choice	If keeping one, choose a legal mid-size fish and release large adults; bass fall in predator meal advice.
Before the trip	Open the Wisconsin DNR water-specific regulation page for WBIC 779200 (Pine) or 850800 (North). Check the exact water, species, and date; the live rule controls if this dated sheet differs.

Keep only a fish you can use

Decide before the cast. Bring ice, stop fishing when the planned meal is secured, and use the species-specific cooking guide for dispatch, bone layout, and safe preparation. Large old predators are valuable spawners and generally carry more mercury than smaller fish.

Sources checked 2026-07-26. Wisconsin DNR lake fish records (Pine WBIC 779200; North WBIC 850800), Wisconsin’s Fishes, Hook Your Catch, 2026–27 water-specific regulations, Catch-and-release Guidelines, and Eating Your Catch. Biological and tactical synthesis is editorial; it is not a current population survey.

Telos. Lake Country Fishing · ChatGPT — Smallmouth Bass. Revised 2026-07-26. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See LICENSE and CREDITS.md in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.

Cooking Smallmouth Bass

Micropterus dolomieu · kitchen guide

From legal fish to boneless meal

START WITH A LAWFUL, COLD FISH

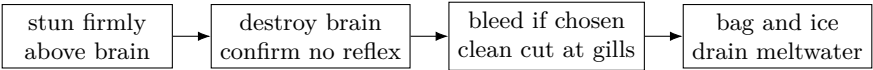
Confirm the live Wisconsin DNR rule and consumption advisory for the exact water, species, length, and date. Kill a retained fish promptly; do not let it suffocate slowly. Bleed only where lawful and practical, then place it in a draining ice slurry or on ice. Keep raw fish at or below 40 °F; wash hands, knife, and board after contact with viscera.

Keep or release?

Legal floor	May 2, 2026–Mar 7, 2027; 14-in minimum; bass daily bag 5 combined on both lakes.
Preferred table fish	A legal lower- to mid-size fish; release large adults.
Why	Mid-size portions are even and large bass are valuable spawners; predators accumulate mercury.

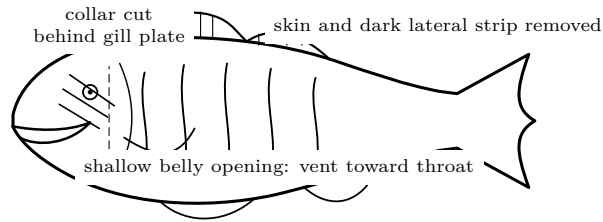
Legal is not the same as desirable. A fish may be lawful yet a poor choice because it is a large breeder, exceeds current meal advice, or cannot be chilled and used promptly.

Dispatch and field care



1. Use a decisive percussive blow to the skull immediately above and just behind the eyes. Follow with a spike or narrow knife into the brain cavity.
2. Confirm loss of rhythmic gill movement and eye reflex. If either remains, repeat immediately. Cut the gill arches only after insensibility.
3. Keep the fish shaded, clean, and cold. Do not soak flesh in warm lake water. At home, work in small batches and return finished portions to ice.

Clean without contaminating the flesh



1. **Set up.** Flexible sharp fillet knife, cut-resistant glove on the non-knife hand, scaler or spoon if needed, pliers, clean towels, two trays.
2. **Scale or skin.** For skinless fillets, leave scales on during cutting, then slide a shallow blade between skin and meat. Trim dark lateral tissue and belly fat.
3. **Open shallowly.** From vent toward the throat, lift the belly wall away from organs and use the tip only. Remove viscera intact. Avoid puncturing the gall bladder; trim and rinse any contaminated tissue.
4. **Kidney line.** Scrape the dark tissue along the backbone and rinse briefly with clean potable water. Pat dry. Never use soap on food.

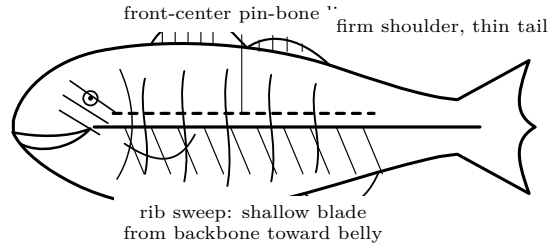
Parasites and raw fish

Freezing and pickling are not substitutes for a validated parasite-control process. Cook wild freshwater fish to an internal temperature of 145 °F, or until opaque and separating easily, unless following a qualified food-safety process. Discard abnormal-smelling or badly diseased flesh; when uncertain, do not eat it.

Species-specific first cuts

Follow the collar around the shoulder, turn at the backbone, and run to tail. Lift and sweep over ribs rather than cutting through them; separate thick shoulder from tail.

Bone map and deboning



1. Keep the skin side down so the blade can ride on, not through, the bones.
2. Remove the rib cage with a shallow sweep, sacrificing as little belly meat as possible. Run fingertips both directions along every cut surface.
3. Brush the centerline both directions. Pull pins in the angle they enter or V-cut the front center; leave as much clean shoulder as possible.
4. Portion only after a final fingertip inspection under a bright light. Bones become harder to locate once batter, crumbs, or sauce is added.

Trim map
Remove rib membrane, belly fat, skin, and dark lateral meat. Trimming does not remove mercury from muscle.

Prepare before heat

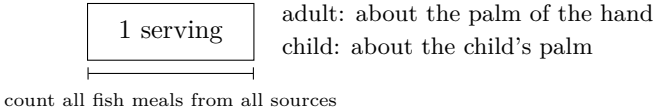
- Pat portions dry. Equal thickness matters more than equal weight.
- Portion the shoulder and tail separately. Pat dry and season simply; do not soak at room temperature.
- Refrigerate while the pan, oven, or grill heats. Marinate under refrigeration; discard marinade that contacted raw fish unless boiled.

Two dependable methods

Herb skillet smallmouth Sear dry portions, turn once, and baste briefly with herb butter; finish to 145 °F.
Foil-steamed bass Seal portions with sliced vegetables and lemon, bake, then open carefully away from steam; verify 145 °F.

Current safe-eating advice · checked 2026-07-26

Statewide inland bass baseline: women under 50 and children under 15, up to one serving/month; women 50+ and men, up to one/week. Check lake and length.



THE QUERY BEATS THE PRINTED SHEET

Wisconsin has a statewide inland baseline and water-specific exceptions. Before eating, use DNR’s Fish Consumption Advisory Query for Pine Lake (WBIC 779200) or North Lake (WBIC 850800), and match species and length. People who are pregnant, may become pregnant, are breastfeeding, and children need the more protective category. When advice changes, follow the current query.

Sources. Wisconsin DNR Eating Your Catch and 2026–27 water-specific regulations; Wisconsin DHS Eat Fish Safely; USDA/FoodSafety.gov Safe Minimum Internal Temperature Chart; University of Minnesota Extension, Preserving Food at Home: Meat, Fish and Poultry. Cleaning sequence and monochrome diagrams are original editorial synthesis, checked 2026-07-26.

Telos. Lake Country Fishing · ChatGPT — Cooking Smallmouth Bass. Revised 2026-07-26. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See LICENSE and CREDITS.md in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.

Recognize it

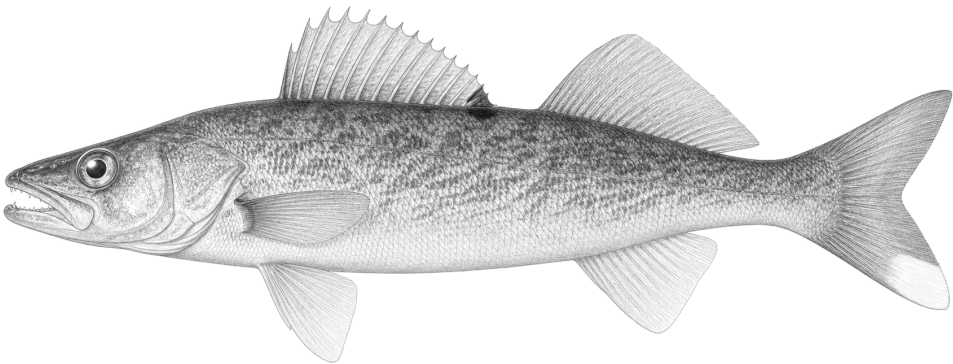
Olive-gold fish with cloudy reflective eye, canine teeth, and white tip on lower tail lobe.

Body	Elongate; separate spiny and soft dorsal fins; dark saddle markings.
Mouth/fins	Large toothed mouth; sharp rear edge on gill cover.
Confusion	Sauger has spots on dorsal fin and no strong white lower-tail tip.

Lake role

Where it belongs
Hard/soft transitions, points, weed edges, basin prey, and low-light shallows.
Food and season
Fish predator; moves with light, temperature, current, and forage.

Identification plate



Original graphite portrait for this ChatGPT edition. Morphology reviewed against Wisconsin DNR species references.

Find it on these waters

Pine	Search deep hard breaks and outside weedline by day; test shallower windward edges in low light.
North	Test narrows/current, weed-to-hard-bottom edges, and evening flats beside depth.
Evidence	The DNR lake records sometimes name only a broad group such as panfish. In that case this species is a candidate member, not verified individual presence. Confirm presence before targeting; treat locations as testable habitat hypotheses, not abundance findings.

Presentations

- 1. **Jig and minnow/plastic.** Use the lightest head that keeps bottom contact without plowing.
- 2. **Slip rig or float.** Slow live bait along a marked contour or suspend it just above fish.
- 3. **Stop rule.** No bottom transition, prey, or marks after a controlled pass means move; do not troll memories.

HANDLING DECIDES THE OUTCOME

Wet hands, avoid gill cover and dorsal spines, use pliers, and support the fish level.

Water-specific rule	May 2, 2026–Mar 7, 2027; 18-in minimum; daily bag 3 on both lakes.
Kitchen choice	Choose a legal lower-end fish rather than a large adult; check length-based consumption advice.
Before the trip	Open the Wisconsin DNR water-specific regulation page for WBIC 779200 (Pine) or 850800 (North). Check the exact water, species, and date; the live rule controls if this dated sheet differs.

Keep only a fish you can use

Decide before the cast. Bring ice, stop fishing when the planned meal is secured, and use the species-specific cooking guide for dispatch, bone layout, and safe preparation. Large old predators are valuable spawners and generally carry more mercury than smaller fish.

Sources checked 2026-07-26. Wisconsin DNR lake fish records (Pine WBIC 779200; North WBIC 850800), Wisconsin’s Fishes, Hook Your Catch, 2026–27 water-specific regulations, Catch-and-release Guidelines, and Eating Your Catch. Biological and tactical synthesis is editorial; it is not a current population survey.

Telos. Lake Country Fishing · ChatGPT — Walleye. Revised 2026-07-26. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See LICENSE and CREDITS.md in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.

START WITH A LAWFUL, COLD FISH

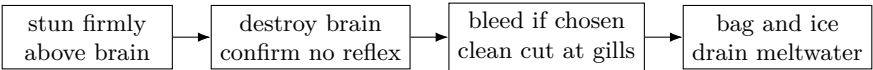
Confirm the live Wisconsin DNR rule and consumption advisory for the exact water, species, length, and date. Kill a retained fish promptly; do not let it suffocate slowly. Bleed only where lawful and practical, then place it in a draining ice slurry or on ice. Keep raw fish at or below 40 °F; wash hands, knife, and board after contact with viscera.

Keep or release?

Legal floor	May 2, 2026–Mar 7, 2027; 18-in minimum; daily bag 3 on both lakes.
Preferred table fish	A legal fish near the lower end; release large females.
Why	Lower-end legal fish portion cleanly; larger older predators are important spawners and tend to carry more mercury.

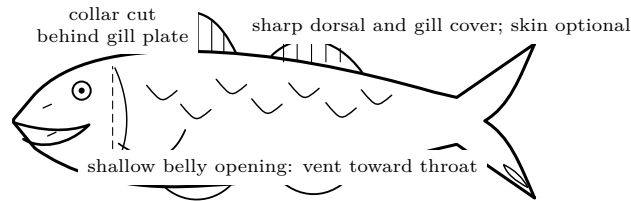
Legal is not the same as desirable. A fish may be lawful yet a poor choice because it is a large breeder, exceeds current meal advice, or cannot be chilled and used promptly.

Dispatch and field care



1. Use a decisive percussive blow to the skull immediately above and just behind the eyes. Follow with a spike or narrow knife into the brain cavity.
2. Confirm loss of rhythmic gill movement and eye reflex. If either remains, repeat immediately. Cut the gill arches only after insensibility.
3. Keep the fish shaded, clean, and cold. Do not soak flesh in warm lake water. At home, work in small batches and return finished portions to ice.

Clean without contaminating the flesh



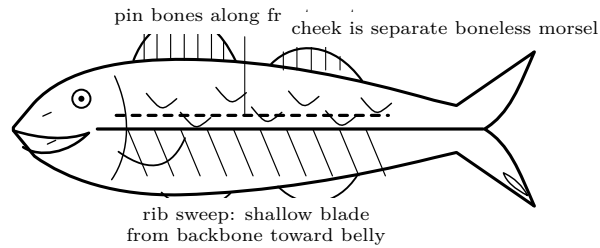
1. **Set up.** Flexible sharp fillet knife, cut-resistant glove on the non-knife hand, scaler or spoon if needed, pliers, clean towels, two trays.
2. **Scale or skin.** For skin-on portions, scale tail-to-head while controlling the spiny dorsal. For classic skinless fillets, leave scales and remove the skin after filleting.
3. **Open shallowly.** From vent toward the throat, lift the belly wall away from organs and use the tip only. Remove viscera intact. Avoid puncturing the gall bladder; trim and rinse any contaminated tissue.
4. **Kidney line.** Scrape the dark tissue along the backbone and rinse briefly with clean potable water. Pat dry. Never use soap on food.

Parasites and raw fish
Freezing and pickling are not substitutes for a validated parasite-control process. Cook wild freshwater fish to an internal temperature of 145 °F, or until opaque and separating easily, unless following a qualified food-safety process. Discard abnormal-smelling or badly diseased flesh; when uncertain, do not eat it.

Species-specific first cuts

Cut tight behind gill plate to backbone, turn toward tail, and follow the frame. Lift and sweep over ribs. Remove cheeks only from a lawfully retained fish with a shallow cut behind the eye.

Bone map and deboning



1. Keep the skin side down so the blade can ride on, not through, the bones.
2. Remove the rib cage with a shallow sweep, sacrificing as little belly meat as possible. Run fingertips both directions along every cut surface.
3. Pull the firm pin bones in their forward angle or V-cut the front-center line. Inspect the shoulder and any cheek pieces independently.
4. Portion only after a final fingertip inspection under a bright light. Bones become harder to locate once batter, crumbs, or sauce is added.

Trim map
Remove rib membrane, belly fat, and dark lateral tissue. Trimmed fat can reduce some fat-soluble contaminants but not mercury.

Prepare before heat

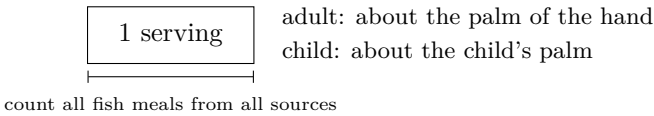
- Pat portions dry. Equal thickness matters more than equal weight.
- Separate thick shoulder from tail; pat dry. Reserve equal portions for the same pan so none overcook.
- Refrigerate while the pan, oven, or grill heats. Marinate under refrigeration; discard marinade that contacted raw fish unless boiled.

Two dependable methods

Classic shallow-fried walleye
Apply a thin dry coating; fry in clean oil, turn once, and verify 145 °F in the thickest shoulder.
Mustard-roasted walleye
Brush with mustard and fine crumbs, roast on a preheated sheet, and remove when the center reaches 145 °F.

Current safe-eating advice · checked 2026-07-26

Statewide inland walleye baseline: women under 50 and children under 15, up to one serving/month; women 50+ and men, up to one/week. Length-specific or lake advice may be stricter.



THE QUERY BEATS THE PRINTED SHEET

Wisconsin has a statewide inland baseline and water-specific exceptions. Before eating, use DNR’s Fish Consumption Advisory Query for Pine Lake (WBIC 779200) or North Lake (WBIC 850800), and match species and length. People who are pregnant, may become pregnant, are breastfeeding, and children need the more protective category. When advice changes, follow the current query.

Sources. Wisconsin DNR Eating Your Catch and 2026–27 water-specific regulations; Wisconsin DHS Eat Fish Safely; USDA/FoodSafety.gov Safe Minimum Internal Temperature Chart; University of Minnesota Extension, Preserving Food at Home: Meat, Fish and Poultry. Cleaning sequence and monochrome diagrams are original editorial synthesis, checked 2026-07-26.

Telos. Lake Country Fishing · ChatGPT — Cooking Walleye. Revised 2026-07-26. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See LICENSE and CREDITS.md in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.

Northern Pike

Esox lucius

Light spots, sharp teeth, weed-edge ambush

Recognize it

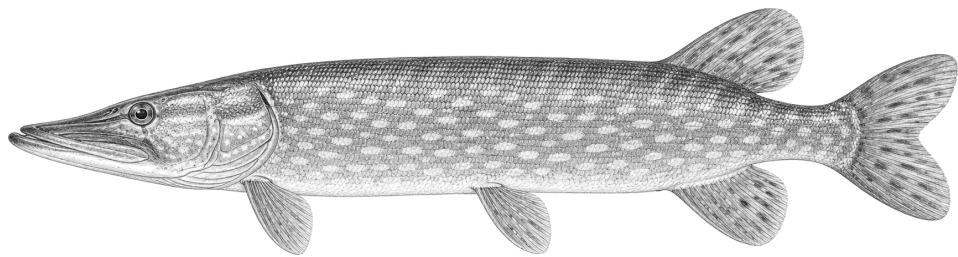
Long green predator with pale oval spots on a darker body and rounded tail lobes.

Body	Cheek fully scaled, lower half of gill cover unscaled; five jaw pores per side.
Mouth/fins	Duckbill snout with backward teeth; dorsal and anal fins far back.
Confusion	Musky usually has dark marks on light body, pointed tail, and six to nine jaw pores.

Lake role

Where it belongs
Weed edges, points, current seams, and cooler deep structure in summer.
Food and season
Fish predator; early shallow vegetation, then follows prey and tolerable temperature.

Identification plate



Original graphite portrait for this ChatGPT edition. Morphology reviewed against Wisconsin DNR species references.

Find it on these waters

Pine	Test spring vegetation and later the deep, cool outside weed edge rather than hot shallows.
North	Test weed walls, narrows, and inlet/outlet current with open water beside cover.
Evidence	The DNR lake records sometimes name only a broad group such as panfish. In that case this species is a candidate member, not verified individual presence. Confirm presence before targeting; treat locations as testable habitat hypotheses, not abundance findings.

Presentations

1. **Spoon or swimbait.** Run parallel to the edge; add pauses while retaining contact above vegetation.
2. **Quick-strike live bait.** Where lawful, use a leader and immediate-set two-hook rig to prevent deep hooking.
3. **Stop rule.** If water is very warm or the fish cannot be landed promptly, target another species.

HANDLING DECIDES THE OUTCOME

Use leader, net, long pliers, and cutters. Keep fingers out of mouth and gills; support fish horizontally.

Water-specific rule	May 2, 2026–Mar 7, 2027; 26-in minimum; daily bag 2 on both lakes.
Kitchen choice	A legal lower-end fish is preferable to a large breeder; use the five-piece Y-bone method.
Before the trip	Open the Wisconsin DNR water-specific regulation page for WBIC 779200 (Pine) or 850800 (North). Check the exact water, species, and date; the live rule controls if this dated sheet differs.

Keep only a fish you can use

Decide before the cast. Bring ice, stop fishing when the planned meal is secured, and use the species-specific cooking guide for dispatch, bone layout, and safe preparation. Large old predators are valuable spawners and generally carry more mercury than smaller fish.

Sources checked 2026-07-26. Wisconsin DNR lake fish records (Pine WBIC 779200; North WBIC 850800), Wisconsin’s Fishes, Hook Your Catch, 2026–27 water-specific regulations, Catch-and-release Guidelines, and Eating Your Catch. Biological and tactical synthesis is editorial; it is not a current population survey.

Telos. Lake Country Fishing · ChatGPT — Northern Pike. Revised 2026-07-26. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See LICENSE and CREDITS.md in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.

START WITH A LAWFUL, COLD FISH

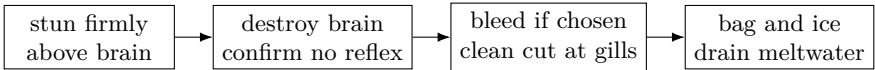
Confirm the live Wisconsin DNR rule and consumption advisory for the exact water, species, length, and date. Kill a retained fish promptly; do not let it suffocate slowly. Bleed only where lawful and practical, then place it in a draining ice slurry or on ice. Keep raw fish at or below 40 °F; wash hands, knife, and board after contact with viscera.

Keep or release?

Legal floor	May 2, 2026–Mar 7, 2027; 26-in minimum; daily bag 2 on both lakes.
Preferred table fish	A legal fish near the lower end of the available range; release large females.
Why	Mid-size flesh portions well; large predators are valuable breeders and generally accumulate more mercury.

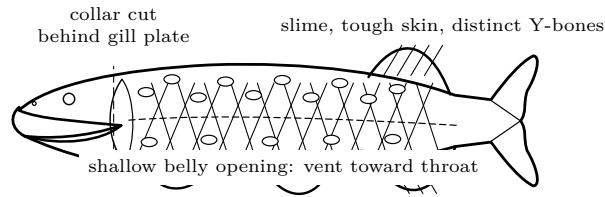
Legal is not the same as desirable. A fish may be lawful yet a poor choice because it is a large breeder, exceeds current meal advice, or cannot be chilled and used promptly.

Dispatch and field care



1. Use a decisive percussive blow to the skull immediately above and just behind the eyes. Follow with a spike or narrow knife into the brain cavity.
2. Confirm loss of rhythmic gill movement and eye reflex. If either remains, repeat immediately. Cut the gill arches only after insensibility.
3. Keep the fish shaded, clean, and cold. Do not soak flesh in warm lake water. At home, work in small batches and return finished portions to ice.

Clean without contaminating the flesh



1. **Set up.** Flexible sharp fillet knife, cut-resistant glove on the non-knife hand, scaler or spoon if needed, pliers, clean towels, two trays.
2. **Scale or skin.** Do not scale. Rinse slime cold, wipe the board, cut the fillets, then remove tough skin with a shallow blade held nearly flat.
3. **Open shallowly.** From vent toward the throat, lift the belly wall away from organs and use the tip only. Remove viscera intact. Avoid puncturing the gall bladder; trim and rinse any contaminated tissue.
4. **Kidney line.** Scrape the dark tissue along the backbone and rinse briefly with clean potable water. Pat dry. Never use soap on food.

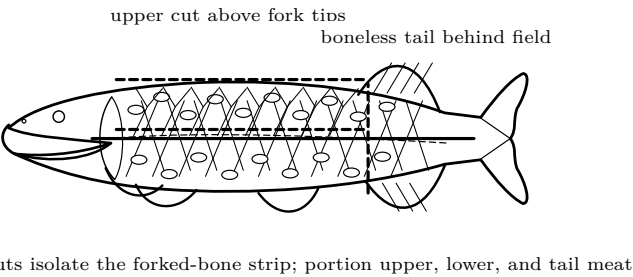
Parasites and raw fish

Freezing and pickling are not substitutes for a validated parasite-control process. Cook wild freshwater fish to an internal temperature of 145 °F, or until opaque and separating easily, unless following a qualified food-safety process. Discard abnormal-smelling or badly diseased flesh; when uncertain, do not eat it.

Species-specific first cuts

Take both side fillets without cutting through ribs, then sweep ribs away. Separate the boneless tail behind the dorsal-fin region before tracing the Y-bone row in the upper front loin.

Bone map and deboning



1. Keep the skin side down so the blade can ride on, not through, the bones.
2. Remove the rib cage with a shallow sweep, sacrificing as little belly meat as possible. Run fingertips both directions along every cut surface.
3. Feel the Y tips. Slice lengthwise immediately above them, then below them, lifting two boneless loins and leaving a narrow bony strip. Do not expect pliers to pull the forked bones intact.
4. Portion only after a final fingertip inspection under a bright light. Bones become harder to locate once batter, crumbs, or sauce is added.

Trim map
Five-piece result: two upper loins, two lower loins, one tail section, plus discarded Y-bone strips. Remove skin, belly lining, and dark lateral tissue.

Prepare before heat

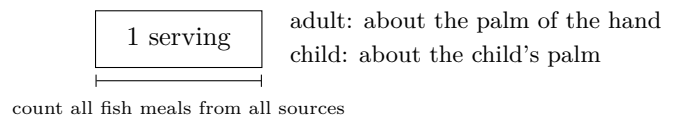
- Pat portions dry. Equal thickness matters more than equal weight.
- Keep the five pieces separate and match thickness. Brine lightly for frying or cut boneless loin into equal poaching portions.
- Refrigerate while the pan, oven, or grill heats. Marinate under refrigeration; discard marinade that contacted raw fish unless boiled.

Two dependable methods

Crisp pike pieces
Coat dry boneless pieces lightly and shallow-fry, turning once; check the thickest piece for 145 °F.
Gentle poached pike
Poach equal loin pieces below a boil in seasoned liquid until opaque and 145 °F; serve immediately or chill rapidly.

Current safe-eating advice · checked 2026-07-26

Statewide inland pike baseline: women under 50 and children under 15, up to one serving/month; women 50+ and men, up to one/week. Check water and length in the current query.



THE QUERY BEATS THE PRINTED SHEET

Wisconsin has a statewide inland baseline and water-specific exceptions. Before eating, use DNR’s Fish Consumption Advisory Query for Pine Lake (WBIC 779200) or North Lake (WBIC 850800), and match species and length. People who are pregnant, may become pregnant, are breastfeeding, and children need the more protective category. When advice changes, follow the current query.

Sources. Wisconsin DNR Eating Your Catch and 2026–27 water-specific regulations; Wisconsin DHS Eat Fish Safely; USDA/FoodSafety.gov Safe Minimum Internal Temperature Chart; University of Minnesota Extension, Preserving Food at Home: Meat, Fish and Poultry. Cleaning sequence and monochrome diagrams are original editorial synthesis, checked 2026-07-26.

Telos. Lake Country Fishing · ChatGPT — Cooking Northern Pike. Revised 2026-07-26. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See LICENSE and CREDITS.md in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.

Candidate module Panfish

The current DNR lake record supports the broad panfish group but does not name these five species individually. Use these sheets for identification only after a catch or current survey confirms the species; do not read inclusion as a presence or abundance claim.

Bluegill

Lepomis macrochirus

Edges, insects, and small precise offerings

Recognize it

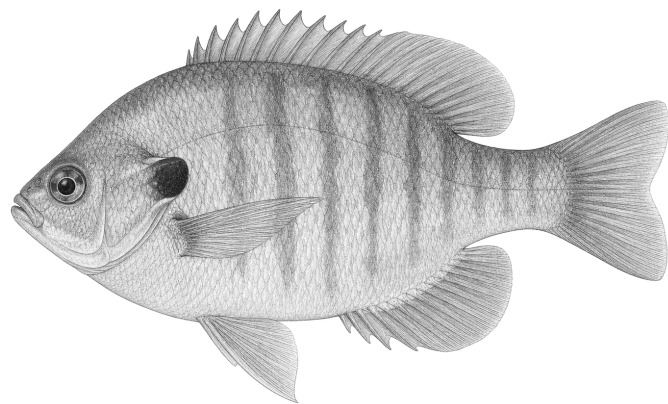
Deep sunfish with a dark flexible ear flap and a blue-black cheek edge.

Body	Compressed oval body; faint bars; breeding males darken at breast.
Mouth/fins	Small mouth; long pointed pectoral fin; continuous spiny dorsal.
Confusion	Pumpkinseed has orange/red on the ear flap and wavy cheek lines.

Lake role

Where it belongs
Vegetation, docks, wood, and firm-bottom nesting colonies.
Food and season
Aquatic insects and small prey; shallow in warm spawning periods, edge-oriented later.

Identification plate



Original graphite portrait for this ChatGPT edition. Morphology reviewed against Wisconsin DNR species references.

Find it on these waters

Pine	Test inside weed pockets early, then deep outside weedline and suspended insect layers.
North	Test protected weed bays, docks where access is lawful, and the outside coontail edge.
Evidence	The DNR lake records sometimes name only a broad group such as panfish. In that case this species is a candidate member, not verified individual presence. Confirm presence before targeting; treat locations as testable habitat hypotheses, not abundance findings.

Presentations

1. **Float and tiny jig.** Use a small hook or jig with worm segment; set depth so bait stays above weed tops.
2. **Vertical micro-jig.** Drop beside deep weeds and watch line for lift bites.
3. **Stop rule.** Downsize only after fish are seen; move when small fish dominate and the goal is a modest meal of adults.

HANDLING DECIDES THE OUTCOME

Wet hands, cradle the body, and fold the dorsal spines flat from front to back.

Water-specific rule	Open all year; no minimum; panfish daily bag 25 on both lakes as listed 2026-07-26.
Kitchen choice	Keep a modest number of mid-size adults; release exceptional males and stop at the meal plan.
Before the trip	Open the Wisconsin DNR water-specific regulation page for WBIC 779200 (Pine) or 850800 (North). Check the exact water, species, and date; the live rule controls if this dated sheet differs.

Keep only a fish you can use

Decide before the cast. Bring ice, stop fishing when the planned meal is secured, and use the species-specific cooking guide for dispatch, bone layout, and safe preparation. Large old predators are valuable spawners and generally carry more mercury than smaller fish.

Sources checked 2026-07-26. Wisconsin DNR lake fish records (Pine WBIC 779200; North WBIC 850800), Wisconsin’s Fishes, Hook Your Catch, 2026–27 water-specific regulations, Catch-and-release Guidelines, and Eating Your Catch. Biological and tactical synthesis is editorial; it is not a current population survey.

Telos. Lake Country Fishing · ChatGPT — Bluegill. Revised 2026-07-26. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See LICENSE and CREDITS.md in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.

Cooking Bluegill

From legal fish to boneless meal

Lepomis macrochirus · kitchen guide

START WITH A LAWFUL, COLD FISH

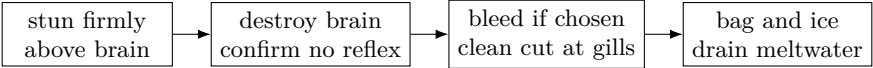
Confirm the live Wisconsin DNR rule and consumption advisory for the exact water, species, length, and date. Kill a retained fish promptly; do not let it suffocate slowly. Bleed only where lawful and practical, then place it in a draining ice slurry or on ice. Keep raw fish at or below 40 °F; wash hands, knife, and board after contact with viscera.

Keep or release?

Legal floor	Open all year; no minimum; panfish daily bag 25 on Pine and North (2026–27 pages).
Preferred table fish	Thick mid-size adults, commonly 7–9 in; release exceptional nest fish.
Why	Small fish yield little; large males protect nests and sustain size structure.

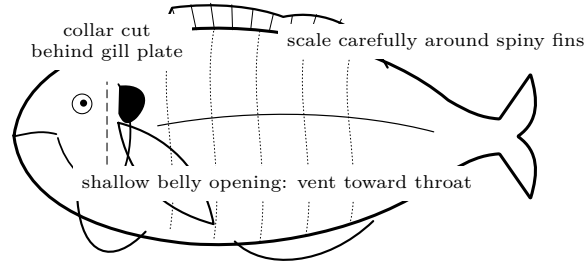
Legal is not the same as desirable. A fish may be lawful yet a poor choice because it is a large breeder, exceeds current meal advice, or cannot be chilled and used promptly.

Dispatch and field care



1. Use a decisive percussive blow to the skull immediately above and just behind the eyes. Follow with a spike or narrow knife into the brain cavity.
2. Confirm loss of rhythmic gill movement and eye reflex. If either remains, repeat immediately. Cut the gill arches only after insensibility.
3. Keep the fish shaded, clean, and cold. Do not soak flesh in warm lake water. At home, work in small batches and return finished portions to ice.

Clean without contaminating the flesh



1. **Set up.** Flexible sharp fillet knife, cut-resistant glove on the non-knife hand, scaler or spoon if needed, pliers, clean towels, two trays.
2. **Scale or skin.** Bluegill skin crisps well. Clip hazardous fin tips if needed, scale tail-to-head outdoors or in a deep sink, then rinse scales away. Skinless fillets may be cut first and skinned flat.
3. **Open shallowly.** From vent toward the throat, lift the belly wall away from organs and use the tip only. Remove viscera intact. Avoid puncturing the gall bladder; trim and rinse any contaminated tissue.
4. **Kidney line.** Scrape the dark tissue along the backbone and rinse briefly with clean potable water. Pat dry. Never use soap on food.

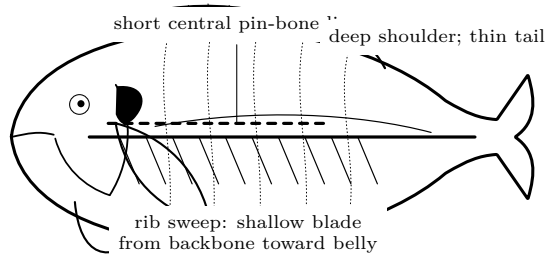
Parasites and raw fish

Freezing and pickling are not substitutes for a validated parasite-control process. Cook wild freshwater fish to an internal temperature of 145 °F, or until opaque and separating easily, unless following a qualified food-safety process. Discard abnormal-smelling or badly diseased flesh; when uncertain, do not eat it.

Species-specific first cuts

Angle behind the pectoral fin to capture shoulder meat, stop at backbone, turn toward tail, then lift and sweep over ribs. On small fish, leave the fillet attached at tail as a skinning handle.

Bone map and deboning



1. Keep the skin side down so the blade can ride on, not through, the bones.
2. Remove the rib cage with a shallow sweep, sacrificing as little belly meat as possible. Run fingertips both directions along every cut surface.
3. Feel the short centerline at the shoulder. Pull larger pins or remove a very narrow V; inspect because small bones hide in the thickest bite.
4. Portion only after a final fingertip inspection under a bright light. Bones become harder to locate once batter, crumbs, or sauce is added.

Trim map

Remove rib membrane and any green gall contamination generously. Scaled, gutted small fish can also be cooked whole after fins and gills are removed.

Prepare before heat

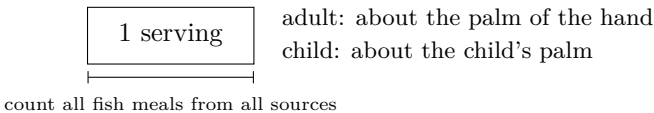
- Pat portions dry. Equal thickness matters more than equal weight.
- Score the skin lightly to prevent curl; dry thoroughly. For whole fish, make shallow cross-slashes to equalize thickness.
- Refrigerate while the pan, oven, or grill heats. Marinate under refrigeration; discard marinade that contacted raw fish unless boiled.

Two dependable methods

Crisp skin-on panfish
Start skin-side down in a lightly oiled skillet; press briefly, then release. Turn once and finish to 145 °F.
Oven-roasted whole bluegill
Season the cleaned cavity, roast on a rack, and check behind the head for 145 °F; lift meat away from the intact skeleton.

Current safe-eating advice · checked 2026-07-26

Statewide inland baseline: women under 50 and children under 15, up to one panfish serving per week; women 50 and over and men, unrestricted panfish servings. Check the lake query.



THE QUERY BEATS THE PRINTED SHEET

Wisconsin has a statewide inland baseline and water-specific exceptions. Before eating, use DNR’s Fish Consumption Advisory Query for Pine Lake (WBIC 779200) or North Lake (WBIC 850800), and match species and length. People who are pregnant, may become pregnant, are breastfeeding, and children need the more protective category. When advice changes, follow the current query.

Sources. Wisconsin DNR Eating Your Catch and 2026–27 water-specific regulations; Wisconsin DHS Eat Fish Safely; USDA/FoodSafety.gov Safe Minimum Internal Temperature Chart; University of Minnesota Extension, Preserving Food at Home: Meat, Fish and Poultry. Cleaning sequence and monochrome diagrams are original editorial synthesis, checked 2026-07-26.

Telos. Lake Country Fishing · ChatGPT — Cooking Bluegill. Revised 2026-07-26. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See LICENSE and CREDITS.md in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.

Recognize it

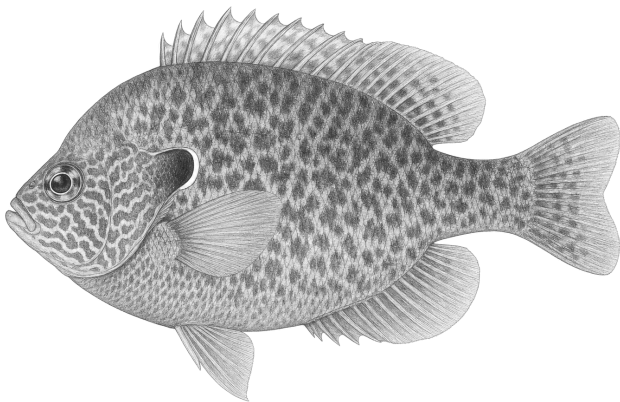
Deep colorful sunfish with turquoise cheek lines and orange/red mark on the ear flap.

Body	Mottled olive sides; orange belly; short rounded pectoral fin.
Mouth/fins	Small mouth; stiff spiny dorsal joined to soft portion.
Confusion	Bluegill lacks the bright ear-flap margin and has a longer pointed pectoral fin.

Lake role

Where it belongs
Vegetated shallows, snails and insect-rich edges, firm spawning pockets.
Food and season
Invertebrates, especially snails and insects; shallow during warm spawning period.

Identification plate



Original graphite portrait for this ChatGPT edition. Morphology reviewed against Wisconsin DNR species references.

Find it on these waters

Pine	Test protected weed pockets and gravel/sand openings, then the first green outside edge.
North	Test shallow vegetation and firm pockets in protected bays.
Evidence	The DNR lake records sometimes name only a broad group such as panfish. In that case this species is a candidate member, not verified individual presence. Confirm presence before targeting; treat locations as testable habitat hypotheses, not abundance findings.

Presentations

- 1. **Tiny float rig.** Present a worm segment or insect imitation near weed openings without burying it.
- 2. **Micro-jig.** Pitch a compact jig to visible pockets and pause near bottom.
- 3. **Stop rule.** Move when only very small fish respond; do not strip a nesting colony for a meal.

HANDLING DECIDES THE OUTCOME

Fold the dorsal spines back, wet hands, and support the body rather than squeezing.

Water-specific rule	Open all year; no minimum; panfish daily bag 25 on both lakes as listed 2026-07-26.
Kitchen choice	Use a modest number of thicker mid-size fish; release exceptional adults and active nest guards.
Before the trip	Open the Wisconsin DNR water-specific regulation page for WBIC 779200 (Pine) or 850800 (North). Check the exact water, species, and date; the live rule controls if this dated sheet differs.

Keep only a fish you can use

Decide before the cast. Bring ice, stop fishing when the planned meal is secured, and use the species-specific cooking guide for dispatch, bone layout, and safe preparation. Large old predators are valuable spawners and generally carry more mercury than smaller fish.

Sources checked 2026-07-26. Wisconsin DNR lake fish records (Pine WBIC 779200; North WBIC 850800), Wisconsin’s Fishes, Hook Your Catch, 2026–27 water-specific regulations, Catch-and-release Guidelines, and Eating Your Catch. Biological and tactical synthesis is editorial; it is not a current population survey.

Telos. Lake Country Fishing · ChatGPT — Pumpkinseed. Revised 2026-07-26. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See LICENSE and CREDITS.md in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.

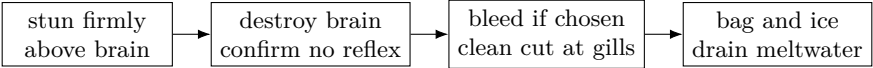
START WITH A LAWFUL, COLD FISH

Confirm the live Wisconsin DNR rule and consumption advisory for the exact water, species, length, and date. Kill a retained fish promptly; do not let it suffocate slowly. Bleed only where lawful and practical, then place it in a draining ice slurry or on ice. Keep raw fish at or below 40 °F; wash hands, knife, and board after contact with viscera.

Keep or release?

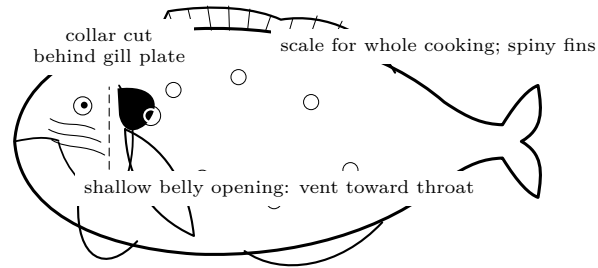
Legal floor	Open all year; no minimum; panfish daily bag 25 on Pine and North (2026–27 pages).
Preferred table fish	Thick mid-size adults; release exceptional fish and nest guards.
Why	Small fish yield little; selective modest harvest protects local size structure.
Legal is not the same as desirable. A fish may be lawful yet a poor choice because it is a large breeder, exceeds current meal advice, or cannot be chilled and used promptly.	

Dispatch and field care



1. Use a decisive percussive blow to the skull immediately above and just behind the eyes. Follow with a spike or narrow knife into the brain cavity.
2. Confirm loss of rhythmic gill movement and eye reflex. If either remains, repeat immediately. Cut the gill arches only after insensibility.
3. Keep the fish shaded, clean, and cold. Do not soak flesh in warm lake water. At home, work in small batches and return finished portions to ice.

Clean without contaminating the flesh



1. **Set up.** Flexible sharp fillet knife, cut-resistant glove on the non-knife hand, scaler or spoon if needed, pliers, clean towels, two trays.
2. **Scale or skin.** Scale tail-to-head if cooking whole or skin-on, paying attention behind fins and gill cover. For skinless fillets, leave scales on and remove the skin after cutting.
3. **Open shallowly.** From vent toward the throat, lift the belly wall away from organs and use the tip only. Remove viscera intact. Avoid puncturing the gall bladder; trim and rinse any contaminated tissue.
4. **Kidney line.** Scrape the dark tissue along the backbone and rinse briefly with clean potable water. Pat dry. Never use soap on food.

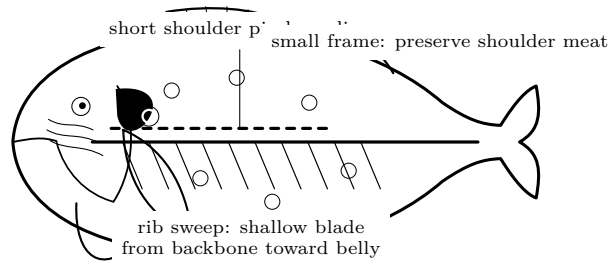
Parasites and raw fish

Freezing and pickling are not substitutes for a validated parasite-control process. Cook wild freshwater fish to an internal temperature of 145 °F, or until opaque and separating easily, unless following a qualified food-safety process. Discard abnormal-smelling or badly diseased flesh; when uncertain, do not eat it.

Species-specific first cuts

Angle the collar cut forward to save shoulder meat, stop at spine, turn to tail, and lift the fillet over the short ribs. Small fish may be gutted and cooked whole instead.

Bone map and deboning



1. Keep the skin side down so the blade can ride on, not through, the bones.
2. Remove the rib cage with a shallow sweep, sacrificing as little belly meat as possible. Run fingertips both directions along every cut surface.
3. Remove the short center pin line with a narrow V. For whole cooked fish, lift the top fillet from the skeleton, then remove the frame and lift the second side.
4. Portion only after a final fingertip inspection under a bright light. Bones become harder to locate once batter, crumbs, or sauce is added.

Trim map
Remove gills and kidney line from whole fish. Fold or clip fin spines so they cannot puncture hands or packaging.

Prepare before heat

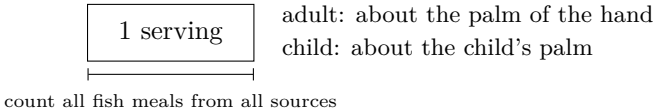
- Pat portions dry. Equal thickness matters more than equal weight.
- For whole fish, slash the thick shoulder twice without reaching bone. For fillets, pair similar thickness and pat dry.
- Refrigerate while the pan, oven, or grill heats. Marinate under refrigeration; discard marinade that contacted raw fish unless boiled.

Two dependable methods

Whole skillet pumpkinseed
Cook scaled, gutted fish in a thin oil layer, turning once; verify 145 °F behind the head, then lift meat from bones at table.
Crumb-baked fillets
Brush dry fillets lightly with oil, add fine crumbs, and bake on a hot sheet to 145 °F.

Current safe-eating advice · checked 2026-07-26

Statewide inland baseline: women under 50 and children under 15, up to one panfish serving/week; women 50+ and men, unrestricted panfish servings. Check the lake query.



THE QUERY BEATS THE PRINTED SHEET

Wisconsin has a statewide inland baseline and water-specific exceptions. Before eating, use DNR's Fish Consumption Advisory Query for Pine Lake (WBIC 779200) or North Lake (WBIC 850800), and match species and length. People who are pregnant, may become pregnant, are breastfeeding, and children need the more protective category. When advice changes, follow the current query.

Sources. Wisconsin DNR Eating Your Catch and 2026–27 water-specific regulations; Wisconsin DHS Eat Fish Safely; USDA/FoodSafety.gov Safe Minimum Internal Temperature Chart; University of Minnesota Extension, Preserving Food at Home: Meat, Fish and Poultry. Cleaning sequence and monochrome diagrams are original editorial synthesis, checked 2026-07-26.

Telos. Lake Country Fishing · ChatGPT — Cooking Pumpkinseed. Revised 2026-07-26. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See LICENSE and CREDITS.md in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.

Black Crappie

Find the school, then hold the depth

Pomoxis nigromaculatus

Recognize it

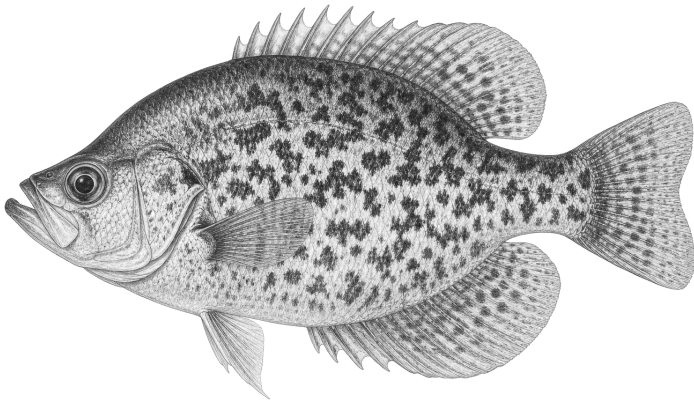
Deep, compressed silver-olive panfish with irregular dark speckles scattered across the sides.

Body	Seven or eight dorsal spines; mottling has no orderly vertical bars.
Mouth/fins	Large upturned mouth; dorsal and anal fins are nearly equal in outline.
Confusion	White crappie usually shows vertical bars and five or six dorsal spines.

Lake role

Where it belongs
Clear-water weeds, wood, basin edges, and suspended schools near prey.
Food and season
Insects and small fish; shallow near spawning cover, then edge or suspend.

Identification plate



Original graphite portrait for this ChatGPT edition. Morphology reviewed against Wisconsin DNR species references.

Find it on these waters

Pine	Test protected new weeds in spring; later scan outside weed edges and open-water prey.
North	Test wood, weed pockets, and the first break near protected spawning water.
Evidence	The DNR lake records sometimes name only a broad group such as panfish. In that case this species is a candidate member, not verified individual presence. Confirm presence before targeting; treat locations as testable habitat hypotheses, not abundance findings.

Presentations

1. **Slip float.** Hang a small jig or live bait just above marked fish; adjust depth before changing color.
2. **Slow vertical jig.** Use a light plastic or hair jig and pause; keep it above the school.
3. **Stop rule.** If no marks, bites, or bait appear in ten minutes, move and search rather than decorating empty water.

HANDLING DECIDES THE OUTCOME

Use wet hands and a small rubber net. Support the body; do not lift a large fish by the lip alone.

Water-specific rule	Open all year; no minimum; panfish daily bag 25 on both lakes as listed 2026-07-26.
Kitchen choice	Prefer abundant hand-size fish; release unusually large adults if a meal is already secured.
Before the trip	Open the Wisconsin DNR water-specific regulation page for WBIC 779200 (Pine) or 850800 (North). Check the exact water, species, and date; the live rule controls if this dated sheet differs.

Keep only a fish you can use

Decide before the cast. Bring ice, stop fishing when the planned meal is secured, and use the species-specific cooking guide for dispatch, bone layout, and safe preparation. Large old predators are valuable spawners and generally carry more mercury than smaller fish.

Sources checked 2026-07-26. Wisconsin DNR lake fish records (Pine WBIC 779200; North WBIC 850800), Wisconsin’s Fishes, Hook Your Catch, 2026–27 water-specific regulations, Catch-and-release Guidelines, and Eating Your Catch. Biological and tactical synthesis is editorial; it is not a current population survey.

Telos. Lake Country Fishing · ChatGPT — Black Crappie. Revised 2026-07-26. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See LICENSE and CREDITS.md in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.

Cooking Black Crappie

Pomoxis nigromaculatus · kitchen guide

From legal fish to boneless meal

START WITH A LAWFUL, COLD FISH

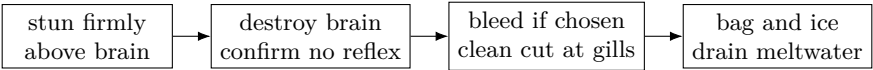
Confirm the live Wisconsin DNR rule and consumption advisory for the exact water, species, length, and date. Kill a retained fish promptly; do not let it suffocate slowly. Bleed only where lawful and practical, then place it in a draining ice slurry or on ice. Keep raw fish at or below 40 °F; wash hands, knife, and board after contact with viscera.

Keep or release?

Legal floor	Open all year; no minimum; panfish daily bag 25 on Pine and North (2026–27 pages).
Preferred table fish	Thick hand-size adults, roughly 9–12 in where abundant.
Why	Enough shoulder meat for a clean fillet; very large crappie are valuable spawners.

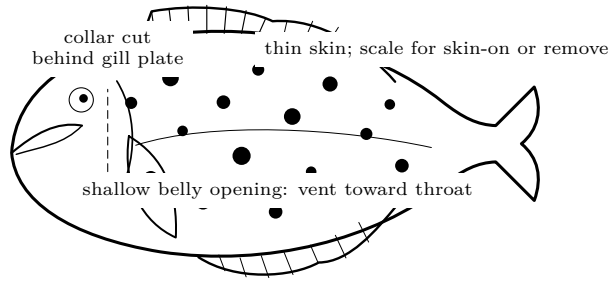
Legal is not the same as desirable. A fish may be lawful yet a poor choice because it is a large breeder, exceeds current meal advice, or cannot be chilled and used promptly.

Dispatch and field care



1. Use a decisive percussive blow to the skull immediately above and just behind the eyes. Follow with a spike or narrow knife into the brain cavity.
2. Confirm loss of rhythmic gill movement and eye reflex. If either remains, repeat immediately. Cut the gill arches only after insensibility.
3. Keep the fish shaded, clean, and cold. Do not soak flesh in warm lake water. At home, work in small batches and return finished portions to ice.

Clean without contaminating the flesh



1. **Set up.** Flexible sharp fillet knife, cut-resistant glove on the non-knife hand, scaler or spoon if needed, pliers, clean towels, two trays.
2. **Scale or skin.** For crisp skin, scale from tail toward head before opening. For skinless portions, leave scales on during filleting so the skin grips the board, then skin the fillet.
3. **Open shallowly.** From vent toward the throat, lift the belly wall away from organs and use the tip only. Remove viscera intact. Avoid puncturing the gall bladder; trim and rinse any contaminated tissue.
4. **Kidney line.** Scrape the dark tissue along the backbone and rinse briefly with clean potable water. Pat dry. Never use soap on food.

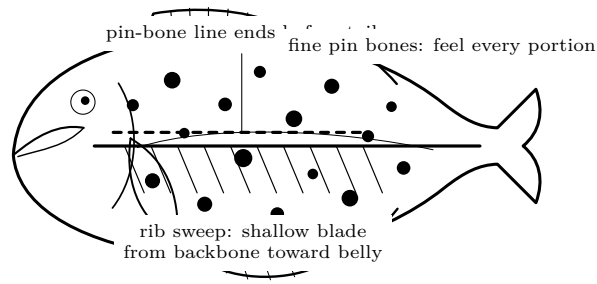
Parasites and raw fish

Freezing and pickling are not substitutes for a validated parasite-control process. Cook wild freshwater fish to an internal temperature of 145 °F, or until opaque and separating easily, unless following a qualified food-safety process. Discard abnormal-smelling or badly diseased flesh; when uncertain, do not eat it.

Species-specific first cuts

Cut behind the gill plate to the backbone. Turn the blade flat and follow the spine to the tail without sawing through it. Lift the fillet, then sweep over the rib cage. Repeat.

Bone map and deboning



1. Keep the skin side down so the blade can ride on, not through, the bones.
2. Remove the rib cage with a shallow sweep, sacrificing as little belly meat as possible. Run fingertips both directions along every cut surface.
3. Pin bones lie along the front-center line. Pull individually toward the head or remove a narrow V-strip; on small fillets the V-strip is safer.
4. Portion only after a final fingertip inspection under a bright light. Bones become harder to locate once batter, crumbs, or sauce is added.

Trim map
Trim the rib membrane and dark bloodline. The spiny dorsal is outside the fillet path; keep the non-knife hand behind it.

Prepare before heat

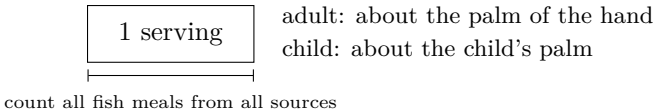
- Pat portions dry. Equal thickness matters more than equal weight.
- For even cooking, pair two small fillets or cut larger shoulders into equal pieces. Season just before heat.
- Refrigerate while the pan, oven, or grill heats. Marinate under refrigeration; discard marinade that contacted raw fish unless boiled.

Two dependable methods

- Shallow-fried cornmeal fillets**
Dust dry fillets lightly; fry in a shallow film of oil until opaque and crisp, turning once. Verify 145 °F at the thickest paired portion.
- Parchment-baked crappie**
Fold fillets with lemon, pepper, and a small pat of butter; bake until the thickest flake separates and reaches 145 °F.

Current safe-eating advice · checked 2026-07-26

Statewide inland baseline: women under 50 and children under 15, up to one panfish serving per week; women 50 and over and men, unrestricted panfish servings. The lake-specific query can be stricter.



THE QUERY BEATS THE PRINTED SHEET

Wisconsin has a statewide inland baseline and water-specific exceptions. Before eating, use DNR's Fish Consumption Advisory Query for Pine Lake (WBIC 779200) or North Lake (WBIC 850800), and match species and length. People who are pregnant, may become pregnant, are breastfeeding, and children need the more protective category. When advice changes, follow the current query.

Sources. Wisconsin DNR Eating Your Catch and 2026–27 water-specific regulations; Wisconsin DHS Eat Fish Safely; USDA/FoodSafety.gov Safe Minimum Internal Temperature Chart; University of Minnesota Extension, Preserving Food at Home: Meat, Fish and Poultry. Cleaning sequence and monochrome diagrams are original editorial synthesis, checked 2026-07-26.

Telos. Lake Country Fishing · ChatGPT — Cooking Black Crappie. Revised 2026-07-26. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See LICENSE and CREDITS.md in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.

Recognize it

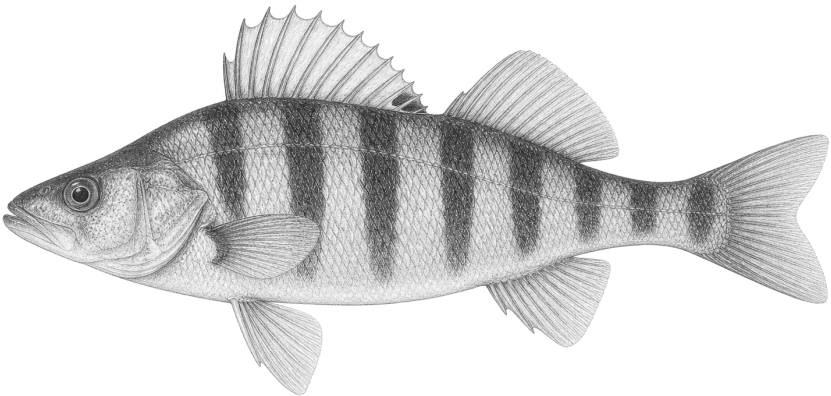
Golden fish with six to nine dark vertical bars and orange lower fins.

Body	Elongate panfish shape; two separate dorsal fins, first strongly spined.
Mouth/fins	Small toothed mouth; sharp gill-cover edge.
Confusion	Juvenile walleye is less golden, lacks orange lower fins, and has white tail tip.

Lake role

Where it belongs
Weeds, sand/gravel, flats beside depth, and winter basin edges.
Food and season
Insects, crayfish, and small fish; schools follow bottom prey and spawning routes.

Identification plate



Original graphite portrait for this ChatGPT edition. Morphology reviewed against Wisconsin DNR species references.

Find it on these waters

Pine	Test deep weed edge and firm flats; use electronics to avoid fishing beneath suspended schools.
North	Test weed-to-sand transitions, narrows, and basin-adjacent flats.
Evidence	The DNR lake records sometimes name only a broad group such as panfish. In that case this species is a candidate member, not verified individual presence. Confirm presence before targeting; treat locations as testable habitat hypotheses, not abundance findings.

Presentations

- 1. **Small jig.** Tip with worm or small plastic; maintain bottom contact with short lifts.
- 2. **Spread search.** Use a float or slow drift until a school is found, then tighten the area.
- 3. **Stop rule.** One fish may be chance; two at the same depth is a pattern. If the school leaves, search again.

HANDLING DECIDES THE OUTCOME

Fold the first dorsal back carefully and avoid the sharp gill-cover edge.

Water-specific rule	Open all year; no minimum; panfish daily bag 25 on both lakes as listed 2026-07-26.
Kitchen choice	Prefer thick mid-size perch; release unusually large females and stop when the meal is complete.
Before the trip	Open the Wisconsin DNR water-specific regulation page for WBIC 779200 (Pine) or 850800 (North). Check the exact water, species, and date; the live rule controls if this dated sheet differs.

Keep only a fish you can use

Decide before the cast. Bring ice, stop fishing when the planned meal is secured, and use the species-specific cooking guide for dispatch, bone layout, and safe preparation. Large old predators are valuable spawners and generally carry more mercury than smaller fish.

Sources checked 2026-07-26. Wisconsin DNR lake fish records (Pine WBIC 779200; North WBIC 850800), Wisconsin’s Fishes, Hook Your Catch, 2026–27 water-specific regulations, Catch-and-release Guidelines, and Eating Your Catch. Biological and tactical synthesis is editorial; it is not a current population survey.

Telos. Lake Country Fishing · ChatGPT — Yellow Perch. Revised 2026-07-26. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See LICENSE and CREDITS.md in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.

START WITH A LAWFUL, COLD FISH

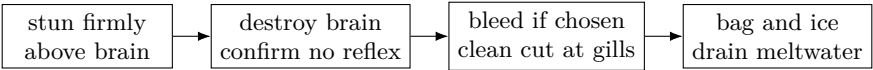
Confirm the live Wisconsin DNR rule and consumption advisory for the exact water, species, length, and date. Kill a retained fish promptly; do not let it suffocate slowly. Bleed only where lawful and practical, then place it in a draining ice slurry or on ice. Keep raw fish at or below 40 °F; wash hands, knife, and board after contact with viscera.

Keep or release?

Legal floor	Open all year; no minimum; panfish daily bag 25 on Pine and North (2026–27 pages).
Preferred table fish	Thick mid-size perch that yield useful portions; release unusually large females.
Why	Good yield without selecting the largest females; a modest school harvest makes one meal.

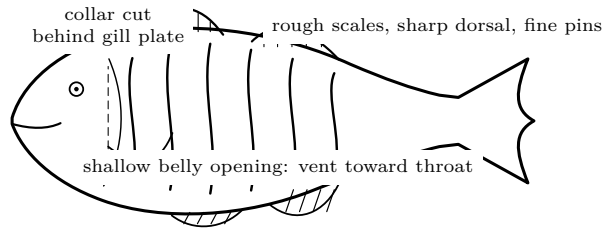
Legal is not the same as desirable. A fish may be lawful yet a poor choice because it is a large breeder, exceeds current meal advice, or cannot be chilled and used promptly.

Dispatch and field care



1. Use a decisive percussive blow to the skull immediately above and just behind the eyes. Follow with a spike or narrow knife into the brain cavity.
2. Confirm loss of rhythmic gill movement and eye reflex. If either remains, repeat immediately. Cut the gill arches only after insensibility.
3. Keep the fish shaded, clean, and cold. Do not soak flesh in warm lake water. At home, work in small batches and return finished portions to ice.

Clean without contaminating the flesh



1. **Set up.** Flexible sharp fillet knife, cut-resistant glove on the non-knife hand, scaler or spoon if needed, pliers, clean towels, two trays.
2. **Scale or skin.** Scale if cooking whole or skin-on. For skinless fillets, leave scales for grip, cut the fillet, then slide it off the skin. Control the first dorsal with the off hand behind the spines.
3. **Open shallowly.** From vent toward the throat, lift the belly wall away from organs and use the tip only. Remove viscera intact. Avoid puncturing the gall bladder; trim and rinse any contaminated tissue.
4. **Kidney line.** Scrape the dark tissue along the backbone and rinse briefly with clean potable water. Pat dry. Never use soap on food.

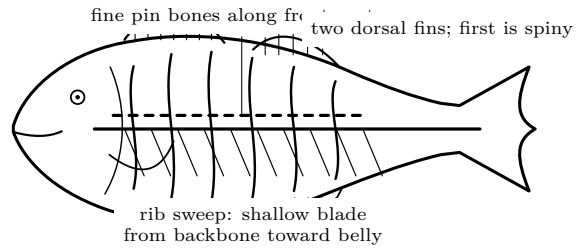
Parasites and raw fish

Freezing and pickling are not substitutes for a validated parasite-control process. Cook wild freshwater fish to an internal temperature of 145°F, or until opaque and separating easily, unless following a qualified food-safety process. Discard abnormal-smelling or badly diseased flesh; when uncertain, do not eat it.

Species-specific first cuts

Make a collar cut behind the pectoral fin, turn along backbone, and sweep over the compact ribs. On small fish, leave the tail attachment as a skinning handle.

Bone map and deboning



1. Keep the skin side down so the blade can ride on, not through, the bones.
2. Remove the rib cage with a shallow sweep, sacrificing as little belly meat as possible. Run fingertips both directions along every cut surface.
3. On larger fillets, pull pins toward the head. On smaller ones, remove a narrow V-strip; run fingers across every portion before coating.
4. Portion only after a final fingertip inspection under a bright light. Bones become harder to locate once batter, crumbs, or sauce is added.

Trim map
Remove rib membrane and dark kidney line. Scaled whole perch should have gills and viscera removed before cooking.

Prepare before heat

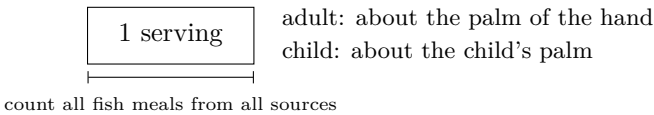
- Pat portions dry. Equal thickness matters more than equal weight.
- Pair similar fillets and dry well. Keep small portions cold until the cooking surface is ready.
- Refrigerate while the pan, oven, or grill heats. Marinate under refrigeration; discard marinade that contacted raw fish unless boiled.

Two dependable methods

Lightly breaded perch
Use a thin coating, shallow-fry without crowding, turn once, and confirm 145 °F in a paired thick portion.
Whole roasted perch
Slash the thick shoulder, season the cavity, roast on a rack to 145 °F, then lift meat cleanly from the frame.

Current safe-eating advice · checked 2026-07-26

Statewide inland baseline: women under 50 and children under 15, up to one panfish serving/week; women 50+ and men, unrestricted panfish servings. Check the lake query.



THE QUERY BEATS THE PRINTED SHEET

Wisconsin has a statewide inland baseline and water-specific exceptions. Before eating, use DNR’s Fish Consumption Advisory Query for Pine Lake (WBIC 779200) or North Lake (WBIC 850800), and match species and length. People who are pregnant, may become pregnant, are breastfeeding, and children need the more protective category. When advice changes, follow the current query.

Sources. Wisconsin DNR Eating Your Catch and 2026–27 water-specific regulations; Wisconsin DHS Eat Fish Safely; USDA/FoodSafety.gov Safe Minimum Internal Temperature Chart; University of Minnesota Extension, Preserving Food at Home: Meat, Fish and Poultry. Cleaning sequence and monochrome diagrams are original editorial synthesis, checked 2026-07-26.

Telos. Lake Country Fishing · ChatGPT — Cooking Yellow Perch. Revised 2026-07-26. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See LICENSE and CREDITS.md in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.

Recognize it

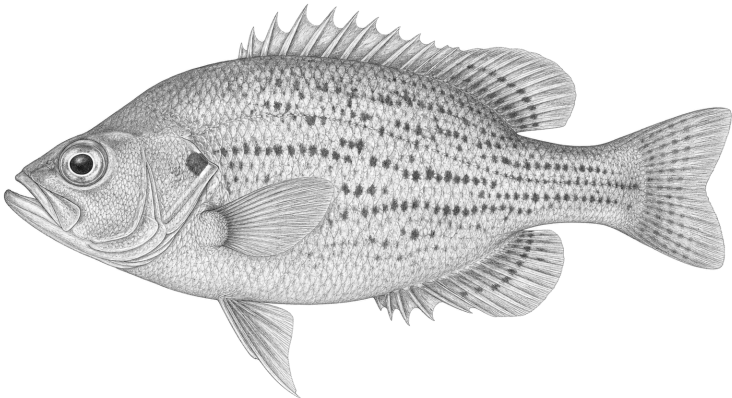
Stocky olive sunfish with red eye and rows of dark side spots.

Body	More elongate than bluegill; five to seven anal spines.
Mouth/fins	Mouth reaches beneath eye; continuous dorsal with strong spines.
Confusion	Warmouth has three anal spines and radiating dark cheek lines.

Lake role

Where it belongs
Rock, wood, docks, shade, and firm transitions.
Food and season
Crayfish, insects, and small fish; often close to bottom or hard cover.

Identification plate



Original graphite portrait for this ChatGPT edition. Morphology reviewed against Wisconsin DNR species references.

Find it on these waters

Pine	Test rocky points, hard-bottom breaks, and shade where accessible.
North	Test wood, riprap, narrows, and firm spots beside weeds.
Evidence	The DNR lake records sometimes name only a broad group such as panfish. In that case this species is a candidate member, not verified individual presence. Confirm presence before targeting; treat locations as testable habitat hypotheses, not abundance findings.

Presentations

- 1. **Small jig.** Hop a compact plastic or hair jig through rock; pause in gaps.
- 2. **Live-bait float.** Suspend worm or small minnow beside cover, not inside the snag.
- 3. **Stop rule.** If only tiny fish bite, move to the next deeper hard edge.

HANDLING DECIDES THE OUTCOME

Beware dorsal and anal spines; wet hands and cradle the fish.

Water-specific rule	Open all year; no minimum; rock/yellow/white bass daily bag unlimited on both lake pages.
Kitchen choice	Keep thicker mid-size fish that yield usable fillets; stop at the planned meal despite no daily limit.
Before the trip	Open the Wisconsin DNR water-specific regulation page for WBIC 779200 (Pine) or 850800 (North). Check the exact water, species, and date; the live rule controls if this dated sheet differs.

Keep only a fish you can use

Decide before the cast. Bring ice, stop fishing when the planned meal is secured, and use the species-specific cooking guide for dispatch, bone layout, and safe preparation. Large old predators are valuable spawners and generally carry more mercury than smaller fish.

Sources checked 2026-07-26. Wisconsin DNR lake fish records (Pine WBIC 779200; North WBIC 850800), Wisconsin’s Fishes, Hook Your Catch, 2026–27 water-specific regulations, Catch-and-release Guidelines, and Eating Your Catch. Biological and tactical synthesis is editorial; it is not a current population survey.

Telos. Lake Country Fishing · ChatGPT — Rock Bass. Revised 2026-07-26. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See LICENSE and CREDITS.md in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.

Cooking Rock Bass

From legal fish to boneless meal

Ambloplites rupestris · kitchen guide

START WITH A LAWFUL, COLD FISH

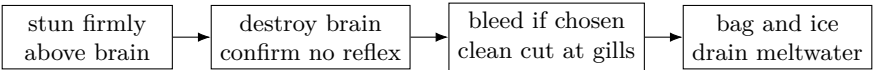
Confirm the live Wisconsin DNR rule and consumption advisory for the exact water, species, length, and date. Kill a retained fish promptly; do not let it suffocate slowly. Bleed only where lawful and practical, then place it in a draining ice slurry or on ice. Keep raw fish at or below 40 °F; wash hands, knife, and board after contact with viscera.

Keep or release?

Legal floor	Open all year; no minimum; rock/yellow/white bass daily bag unlimited on both lake pages.
Preferred table fish	Thick mid-size fish with enough shoulder for a clean fillet.
Why	No daily limit is not a harvest target; smaller fish cost time and larger adults sustain the population.

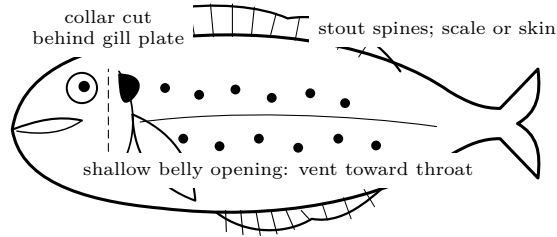
Legal is not the same as desirable. A fish may be lawful yet a poor choice because it is a large breeder, exceeds current meal advice, or cannot be chilled and used promptly.

Dispatch and field care



1. Use a decisive percussive blow to the skull immediately above and just behind the eyes. Follow with a spike or narrow knife into the brain cavity.
2. Confirm loss of rhythmic gill movement and eye reflex. If either remains, repeat immediately. Cut the gill arches only after insensibility.
3. Keep the fish shaded, clean, and cold. Do not soak flesh in warm lake water. At home, work in small batches and return finished portions to ice.

Clean without contaminating the flesh



1. **Set up.** Flexible sharp fillet knife, cut-resistant glove on the non-knife hand, scaler or spoon if needed, pliers, clean towels, two trays.
2. **Scale or skin.** Scale for whole or skin-on cooking, working around the stout dorsal and anal spines. Otherwise leave scales on, fillet, and remove skin flat.
3. **Open shallowly.** From vent toward the throat, lift the belly wall away from organs and use the tip only. Remove viscera intact. Avoid puncturing the gall bladder; trim and rinse any contaminated tissue.
4. **Kidney line.** Scrape the dark tissue along the backbone and rinse briefly with clean potable water. Pat dry. Never use soap on food.

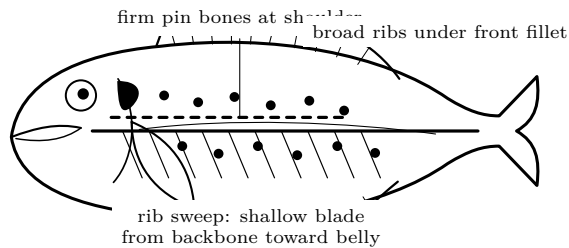
Parasites and raw fish

Freezing and pickling are not substitutes for a validated parasite-control process. Cook wild freshwater fish to an internal temperature of 145 °F, or until opaque and separating easily, unless following a qualified food-safety process. Discard abnormal-smelling or badly diseased flesh; when uncertain, do not eat it.

Species-specific first cuts

Cut behind gill plate, follow backbone to tail, then sweep across the broad rib cage. The shoulder carries most usable meat, so keep the first cut tight to the head.

Bone map and deboning



1. Keep the skin side down so the blade can ride on, not through, the bones.
2. Remove the rib cage with a shallow sweep, sacrificing as little belly meat as possible. Run fingertips both directions along every cut surface.
3. Pull the few firm shoulder pins in their forward angle or remove a narrow V-strip. Recheck the thick shoulder from both directions.
4. Portion only after a final fingertip inspection under a bright light. Bones become harder to locate once batter, crumbs, or sauce is added.

Trim map
Remove rib membrane and dark lateral strip. Whole-fish cooks must remove gills, viscera, and kidney line.

Prepare before heat

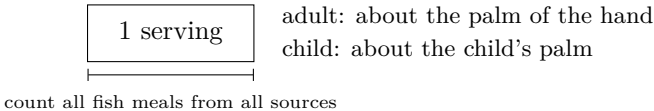
- Pat portions dry. Equal thickness matters more than equal weight.
- Separate thick shoulders from tails for even timing. A short salt rest firms the flesh; keep refrigerated.
- Refrigerate while the pan, oven, or grill heats. Marinate under refrigeration; discard marinade that contacted raw fish unless boiled.

Two dependable methods

Pan-roasted rock bass Brown skin-on or skinless portions, lower heat, and finish gently to 145 °F.
Fish cakes Cook boneless fish to 145 °F, cool, flake and inspect again, bind lightly, then brown patties; refrigerate mixture during handling.

Current safe-eating advice · checked 2026-07-26

Wisconsin treats rock bass with panfish for statewide inland advice: under-50 women and children under 15, up to one/week; women 50+ and men, unrestricted. Check lake-specific advice.



THE QUERY BEATS THE PRINTED SHEET

Wisconsin has a statewide inland baseline and water-specific exceptions. Before eating, use DNR's Fish Consumption Advisory Query for Pine Lake (WBIC 779200) or North Lake (WBIC 850800), and match species and length. People who are pregnant, may become pregnant, are breastfeeding, and children need the more protective category. When advice changes, follow the current query.

Sources. Wisconsin DNR Eating Your Catch and 2026–27 water-specific regulations; Wisconsin DHS Eat Fish Safely; USDA/FoodSafety.gov Safe Minimum Internal Temperature Chart; University of Minnesota Extension, Preserving Food at Home: Meat, Fish and Poultry. Cleaning sequence and monochrome diagrams are original editorial synthesis, checked 2026-07-26.

Telos. Lake Country Fishing · ChatGPT — Cooking Rock Bass. Revised 2026-07-26. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See LICENSE and CREDITS.md in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.

III Rigs

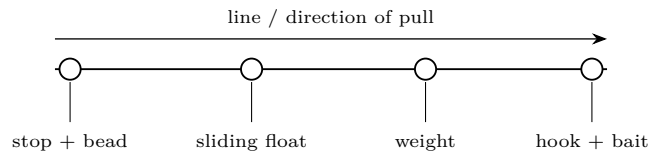
Build and fish the presentation as a system. Hook choice, leader, weight, depth, and stop rule matter more than a lure name.

Slip bobber

Rig sheet — original assembly diagram

ChatGPT edition

Job. Suspends bait at a measured depth while remaining castable.



Components and build

Thread stop, bead and float; add only enough weight to stand the float; tie a small hook. Set the stop to the target depth and test beside the boat.

Fish it

Cast beyond the target, reel into position, and watch for lift, travel or submergence. Reel tight before a smooth hook-set.

Pine Lake Probe the outside vegetation edge and island saddle.

North Lake Cover panfish water on the north flat and lobe rims.

Adjustment Move the stop in one-foot steps until bites repeat.

CONTROL THE HOOKS, FISH AND LAW

Keep loose hooks secured; a float is not a substitute for watching the line. Use tackle strong enough to retrieve the target promptly. Prepare pliers and a knotless rubber net before the cast. If a hook is deep, cutting the line can be less damaging than prolonged extraction. Verify exact-water 2026–27 rules, hook count, bait law and seasons before every trip.

Source basis: Wisconsin DNR Hook, Line & Thinker; Hook Your Catch; Catch-and-Release Guidelines; Boat Transportation and Bait Laws.

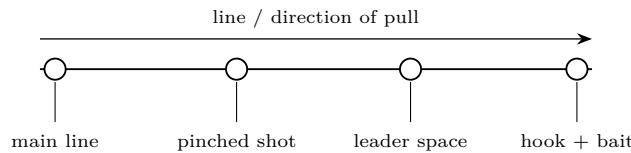
Telos. Lake Country Fishing — Slip bobber. Revised 2026-07-26. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See **LICENSE** and **CREDITS.md** in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.

Split-shot rig

Rig sheet — original assembly diagram

ChatGPT edition

Job. Presents a small bait naturally with minimal hardware.



Components and build

Tie the hook first. Pinch one removable shot 12–24 in above it without damaging the line; add weight only when wind or depth demands it.

Fish it

Cast gently, let it settle, then crawl or swim it with pauses while keeping enough contact to detect a change.

Pine Lake Use on gradual west shelves and quiet pockets.

North Lake Use over shallow flats and the central saddle.

Adjustment Increase leader space for softer fall; shorten it for control.

CONTROL THE HOOKS, FISH AND LAW

Wear eye protection when pinching or removing shot; discard damaged line. Use tackle strong enough to retrieve the target promptly. Prepare pliers and a knotless rubber net before the cast. If a hook is deep, cutting the line can be less damaging than prolonged extraction. Verify exact-water 2026–27 rules, hook count, bait law and seasons before every trip.

Source basis: Wisconsin DNR Hook, Line & Thinker; Hook Your Catch; Catch-and-Release Guidelines; Boat Transportation and Bait Laws.

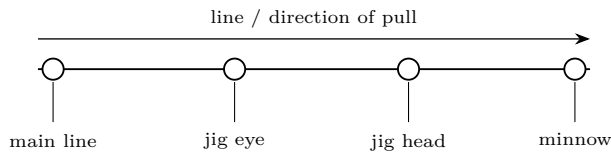
Telos. Lake Country Fishing — Split-shot rig. Revised 2026-07-26. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See **LICENSE** and **CREDITS.md** in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.

Jig and minnow

Rig sheet — original assembly diagram

ChatGPT edition

Job. Combines depth control with live-bait movement.



Components and build

Tie directly with a sound knot. Choose the lightest head that reaches bottom and remains detectable. Hook bait to preserve movement; obey bait law.

Fish it

Lower or cast, find bottom, lift briefly and follow the fall on a controlled line. Strike when weight, rhythm or direction changes.

Pine Lake	Work hard breaks and the island saddle.
North Lake	Work channel lips and eastern breaks.
Adjustment	Change head weight before changing the entire presentation.

CONTROL THE HOOKS, FISH AND LAW

Control the exposed hook and never transport live fish away from the water. Use tackle strong enough to retrieve the target promptly. Prepare pliers and a knotless rubber net before the cast. If a hook is deep, cutting the line can be less damaging than prolonged extraction. Verify exact-water 2026–27 rules, hook count, bait law and seasons before every trip.

Source basis: Wisconsin DNR Hook, Line & Thinker; Hook Your Catch; Catch-and-Release Guidelines; Boat Transportation and Bait Laws.

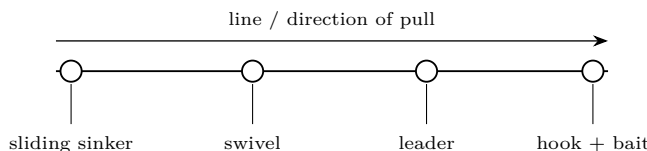
Telos. Lake Country Fishing — Jig and minnow. Revised 2026-07-26. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See LICENSE and CREDITS.md in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.

Lindy rig

Rig sheet — original assembly diagram

ChatGPT edition

Job. Separates a walking sinker from a slowly moving bait.



Components and build

Slide sinker onto main line, tie swivel, then add a 3–6 ft leader and hook. Use a leader that keeps the bait clear without defeating control.

Fish it

Drift or troll slowly enough to feel bottom. Feed brief slack after a pickup, then reel tight; avoid prolonged delay that encourages deep hooking.

Pine Lake	Follow long 20–40 ft basin edges.
North Lake	Trace the main-basin wall and west-lobe rim.
Adjustment	Shorten the leader in weeds; lengthen over clean hard bottom.

CONTROL THE HOOKS, FISH AND LAW

Watch other lines and traffic; motor trolling limits must be rechecked. Use tackle strong enough to retrieve the target promptly. Prepare pliers and a knotless rubber net before the cast. If a hook is deep, cutting the line can be less damaging than prolonged extraction. Verify exact-water 2026–27 rules, hook count, bait law and seasons before every trip.

Source basis: Wisconsin DNR Hook, Line & Thinker; Hook Your Catch; Catch-and-Release Guidelines; Boat Transportation and Bait Laws.

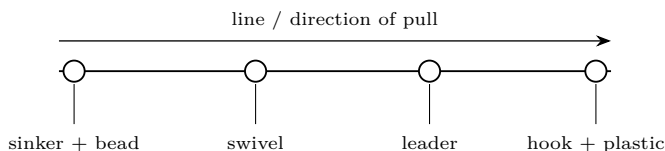
Telos. Lake Country Fishing — Lindy rig. Revised 2026-07-26. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See [LICENSE](#) and [CREDITS.md](#) in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.

Carolina rig

ChatGPT edition

Rig sheet — original assembly diagram

Job. Carries a soft plastic along bottom behind a sliding weight.



Components and build

Slide sinker and bead onto main line; tie swivel; add leader and an offset hook. Rig the plastic straight so it tracks without spinning.

Fish it

Cast across a contour, settle, then sweep with the rod and recover slack. Pause on hard-bottom changes.

Pine Lake Search broad gravel shelves and tapers.

North Lake Search the north flat and saddle approaches.

Adjustment Lighter weight is quieter; heavier weight improves depth certainty.

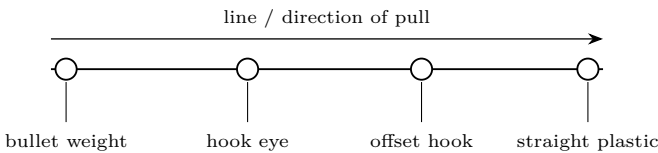
CONTROL THE HOOKS, FISH AND LAW

Do not snap a loaded sinker toward people or fragile equipment. Use tackle strong enough to retrieve the target promptly. Prepare pliers and a knotless rubber net before the cast. If a hook is deep, cutting the line can be less damaging than prolonged extraction. Verify exact-water 2026–27 rules, hook count, bait law and seasons before every trip.

Source basis: Wisconsin DNR Hook, Line & Thinker; Hook Your Catch; Catch-and-Release Guidelines; Boat Transportation and Bait Laws.

Telos. Lake Country Fishing — Carolina rig. Revised 2026-07-26. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See **LICENSE** and **CREDITS.md** in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.

Job. Makes a soft plastic compact and weed-resistant.



Components and build

Slide on a bullet weight, tie an offset hook, enter the plastic head, rotate, then bury or skin-hook the point while keeping the body straight.

Fish it

Pitch to edges and openings, let it fall on controlled line, then lift or drag. Watch the line before feeling the fish.

- Pine Lake**
- Work west vegetation and protected pockets.
- North Lake**
- Work flats, saddle weeds and shoreline cover.
- Adjustment**
- Peg only when cover requires the weight and bait to stay together.

CONTROL THE HOOKS, FISH AND LAW

“Weedless” is not hookless; check behind and use controlled short casts. Use tackle strong enough to retrieve the target promptly. Prepare pliers and a knotless rubber net before the cast. If a hook is deep, cutting the line can be less damaging than prolonged extraction. Verify exact-water 2026–27 rules, hook count, bait law and seasons before every trip.

Source basis: Wisconsin DNR Hook, Line & Thinker; Hook Your Catch; Catch-and-Release Guidelines; Boat Transportation and Bait Laws.

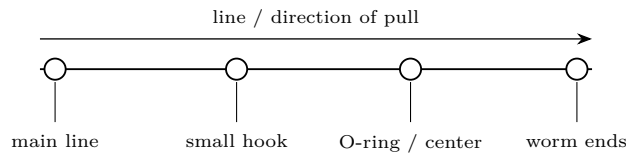
Telos. Lake Country Fishing — Texas rig. Revised 2026-07-26. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See LICENSE and CREDITS.md in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.

Wacky rig

ChatGPT edition

Rig sheet — original assembly diagram

Job. Lets both ends of a straight worm pulse on a slow fall.



Components and build

Tie a small hook and place it through an O-ring at the worm midpoint, or through the plastic when necessary. Start weightless.

Fish it

Cast past the target, allow a slack-controlled fall, lift once or twice, and repeat. Most takes occur on the fall.

Pine Lake Use over clear shelf edges with long casts.

North Lake Use around shallow breaks and sparse cover.

Adjustment Add minimal weight only when depth or wind prevents control.

CONTROL THE HOOKS, FISH AND LAW

Use line and tackle capable of steering bass away from cover promptly. Use tackle strong enough to retrieve the target promptly. Prepare pliers and a knotless rubber net before the cast. If a hook is deep, cutting the line can be less damaging than prolonged extraction. Verify exact-water 2026–27 rules, hook count, bait law and seasons before every trip.

Source basis: Wisconsin DNR Hook, Line & Thinker; Hook Your Catch; Catch-and-Release Guidelines; Boat Transportation and Bait Laws.

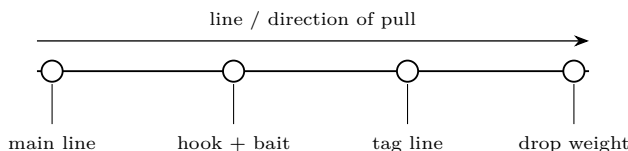
Telos. Lake Country Fishing — Wacky rig. Revised 2026-07-26. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See LICENSE and CREDITS.md in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.

Drop-shot

ChatGPT edition

Rig sheet — original assembly diagram

Job. Holds a small bait above bottom for precise vertical control.



Components and build

Tie the hook leaving a long tag; pass the tag back through the eye so the point stands out; attach a drop weight 8–24 in below.

Fish it

Lower to marked fish or cast short. Keep the weight down and animate the bait without dragging constantly.

Pine Lake Use on the island edge and steep east-side structure.

North Lake Use along the main-basin wall and compact humps.

Adjustment Match hook height to vegetation and fish height.

CONTROL THE HOOKS, FISH AND LAW

Vertical depth can increase barotrauma risk; plan release depth conservatively. Use tackle strong enough to retrieve the target promptly. Prepare pliers and a knotless rubber net before the cast. If a hook is deep, cutting the line can be less damaging than prolonged extraction. Verify exact-water 2026–27 rules, hook count, bait law and seasons before every trip.

Source basis: Wisconsin DNR Hook, Line & Thinker; Hook Your Catch; Catch-and-Release Guidelines; Boat Transportation and Bait Laws.

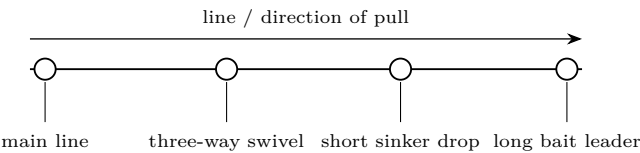
Telos. Lake Country Fishing — Drop-shot. Revised 2026-07-26. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See **LICENSE** and **CREDITS.md** in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.

Three-way rig

Rig sheet — original assembly diagram

ChatGPT edition

Job. Separates bait and sinker on two branches for controlled depth.



Components and build

Tie the main line to one swivel eye, a sacrificial sinker drop to the second, and a longer leader with hook or lure to the third. Test for tangles.

Fish it

Move slowly along a contour with sinker contact intermittent, not plowing. Keep leader clear during turns.

- | | |
|-------------------|---|
| Pine Lake | Trace long deep basin edges. |
| North Lake | Follow the eastern wall and central corridor. |
| Adjustment | Shorten both branches in weeds or current. |

CONTROL THE HOOKS, FISH AND LAW

Multiple branches tangle easily; transport assembled rigs in a keeper. Use tackle strong enough to retrieve the target promptly. Prepare pliers and a knotless rubber net before the cast. If a hook is deep, cutting the line can be less damaging than prolonged extraction. Verify exact-water 2026–27 rules, hook count, bait law and seasons before every trip.

Source basis: Wisconsin DNR Hook, Line & Thinker; Hook Your Catch; Catch-and-Release Guidelines; Boat Transportation and Bait Laws.

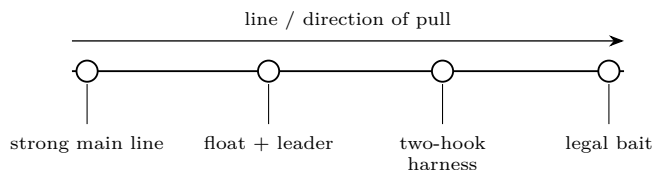
Telos. Lake Country Fishing — Three-way rig. Revised 2026-07-26. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See LICENSE and CREDITS.md in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.

Quick-strike rig

Rig sheet — original assembly diagram

ChatGPT edition

Job. Supports a large legal live bait for an immediate predator hook-set.



Components and build

Use predator-rated line, leader and a purpose-built two-hook harness sized to the bait and target. Balance the float; keep points exposed and separated.

Fish it

Attend continuously. On a take, remove slack and set promptly rather than waiting for swallowing. Land, unhook and release or dispatch efficiently.

Pine Lake Test weed edges only where current species rules allow.

North Lake Test lobe rims and vegetation only where lawful.

Adjustment Change float size and depth, not hook delay.

CONTROL THE HOOKS, FISH AND LAW

Two hooks and large fish create severe puncture risk. Use long pliers, cutters, gloves and a large rubber net; never hand-land. Use tackle strong enough to retrieve the target promptly. Prepare pliers and a knotless rubber net before the cast. If a hook is deep, cutting the line can be less damaging than prolonged extraction. Verify exact-water 2026–27 rules, hook count, bait law and seasons before every trip.

Source basis: Wisconsin DNR Hook, Line & Thinker; Hook Your Catch; Catch-and-Release Guidelines; Boat Transportation and Bait Laws.

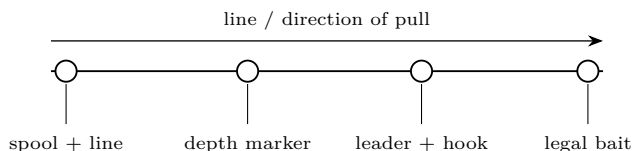
Telos. Lake Country Fishing — Quick-strike rig. Revised 2026-07-26. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See LICENSE and CREDITS.md in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.

Tip-up

ChatGPT edition

Rig sheet — original assembly diagram

Job. Suspends bait below ice and signals line movement.



Components and build

Sound depth, set a repeatable marker, attach lawful leader/hook and bait, then position the spool so the flag trips freely. Keep the hole managed.

Fish it

Attend every device. After a flag, approach quietly, confirm purposeful line movement, remove slack and set smoothly; land without wrapping line on hands.

Pine Lake	Away from narrows/current; target known weed edges only after local assessment.
North Lake	Avoid the channel, saddle current and south neck.
Adjustment	Reset from the marker after every fish.

CONTROL THE HOOKS, FISH AND LAW

No thickness makes ice completely safe. Carry flotation, picks, rope and a waterproof phone; travel with others and leave a plan. Use tackle strong enough to retrieve the target promptly. Prepare pliers and a knotless rubber net before the cast. If a hook is deep, cutting the line can be less damaging than prolonged extraction. Verify exact-water 2026–27 rules, hook count, bait law and seasons before every trip.

Source basis: Wisconsin DNR Hook, Line & Thinker; Hook Your Catch; Catch-and-Release Guidelines; Boat Transportation and Bait Laws.

Telos. Lake Country Fishing — Tip-up. Revised 2026-07-26. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See LICENSE and CREDITS.md in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.

IV Reference

Use these sheets across targets: interpret structure and season, select bait deliberately, tie and inspect connections, handle fish before the cast, and run a safe first trip.

Reading Water

ChatGPT edition

Turn observations into tests

Read in this order

Signal	What it can mean	Test, not conclusion
Windward edge	Food and warmer surface water may collect.	Make one controlled pass, then compare the sheltered side.
Point / inside turn	Travel route between depths.	Cast across and along it; record the depth of every contact.
Vegetation edge	Cover plus an oxygen/light boundary.	Find the actual outside edge today; old maps cannot show it.
Hard/soft change	Different prey and spawning habitat.	Use bottom feel or lawful electronics; mark where texture changes.
Bait on electronics	Forage is present at that moment.	Fish its depth, including suspended water; leave if predators never appear.
Temperature / clarity	Changes visibility, metabolism and plant depth.	Adjust distance, speed, size and depth one variable at a time.

Three-pass method

First pass maps depth, bottom and cover. Second pass holds presentation constant through the best feature. Third pass changes one variable. A named “spot” is only a hypothesis until current evidence supports it.

MAP DISCIPLINE

Historical lake contours are generalized and not for navigation. Watch traffic, weather, depth and hazards directly. Never stare at electronics while underway.

Source basis: Wisconsin DNR Hook Your Catch and lake records; editorial test method.

Telos. Lake Country Fishing — Reading Water. Revised 2026-07-26. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See LICENSE and CREDITS.md in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.

Lures & Baits

ChatGPT edition

Choose by job

Tool	Job	Start on these lakes	Adjustment
Small jig	Depth contact; compact prey	Breaks, saddle, panfish or walleye search	Change weight first.
Slip bobber + legal bait	Hold exact depth	Vegetation edges and flats	Move stop in one-foot steps.
Straight soft worm	Slow bass fall	Sparse cover and clear shelf edges	Weightless, then minimally weighted.
Weedless plastic	Enter vegetation	West Pine shelf; North flats	Match weight to penetration needed.
Crankbait	Cover water at a band	Hard edges with safe clearance	Choose running depth, then speed.
Spinner / spoon	Flash and vibration	Weed lanes and active pike water	Add a bite-resistant leader when warranted.
Live minnow	Natural movement	Jig, float or lawful predator rig	Keep lively; obey purchase and transport law.
Leech / crawler	Slow natural bait	Float or bottom rig	Use only what can be presented and released responsibly.

BAIT IS REGULATED

Inspect, remove and drain before transport. Do not move live fish away from a waterbody. Put unwanted bait in trash and obey current source, water and transport rules. Secure every exposed hook in storage.

Source basis: Wisconsin DNR Hook Your Catch; Fishing for Dinner; Boat Transportation and Bait Laws.

Telos. Lake Country Fishing — Lures & Baits. Revised 2026-07-26. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See [LICENSE](#) and [CREDITS.md](#) in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.

Seasonal Calendar

Phenology, not a guarantee

ChatGPT edition

Period	Starting hypothesis	Evidence to seek
Ice-out / early spring	Protected shallows may warm first; pike and panfish may use emerging cover.	Temperature difference, green growth, bait and legal season.
Late spring	Spawning and post-spawn movement can concentrate fish shallow.	Beds, recovering fish, water temperature; avoid damaging nests.
Early summer	Vegetation edges and hard-bottom breaks develop.	Actual weed depth, insect activity and repeated contact depth.
Mid-summer	Some fish use deep edges or suspend; oxygen can constrain usable depth.	Thermocline/oxygen evidence, bait height, warm-water release risk.
Early fall	Cooling can redistribute forage and predators.	Turnover signs, temperature uniformity, wind and bait.
Late fall	Slow, depth-controlled presentations often become useful.	Bottom contact, short feeding windows, cold-water safety.
Ice season	Tip-ups and small vertical lures can cover lawful targets.	Current local ice assessment; avoid inlets, outlets and narrows.

CALENDAR DOES NOT OPEN A SEASON

For 2026–27, resolve the exact water, species and date in current Wisconsin DNR rules. No date, appearance or reported thickness makes ice completely safe.

Source basis: Wisconsin DNR season dates, Hook Your Catch and Ice Safety.

Telos. Lake Country Fishing — Seasonal Calendar. Revised 2026-07-26. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See LICENSE and CREDITS.md in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.

Four Working Knots

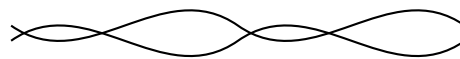
ChatGPT edition

Tie, inspect, test

Improved clinch	Pass through eye; make 5–7 wraps; return through the first loop, then the large loop; moisten and draw tight. General hook/lure knot.
Palomar	Double line through eye; tie a loose overhand; pass loop over tackle; moisten and seat without crossing strands. Strong when the doubled loop fits.
Uni knot	Pass through eye; form a loop alongside standing line; wrap tag through loop 5–7 times; moisten, close, and slide to eye. Versatile connection.
Surgeon's loop	Double the line; make an overhand loop, pass doubled end through twice; moisten and seat evenly. Useful for loop-to-loop leaders.

Every time

Leave enough tag to finish correctly. Wet monofilament/fluorocarbon before seating. Pull standing line and tag firmly, inspect for crossing, flattening or heat damage, trim safely, then test harder than the expected presentation load. Retie after abrasion, snags, tooth contact or unexplained failure.



seat wraps side by side; reject crossed coils

HOOKS UNDER TENSION

Point hooks away from faces and hands. Wear eye protection when testing or pulling free. Cut snagged line under control; never snap it toward the boat.

Source basis: Wisconsin DNR Hook, Line & Thinker.

Telos. Lake Country Fishing — Four Working Knots. Revised 2026-07-26. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See LICENSE and CREDITS.md in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.

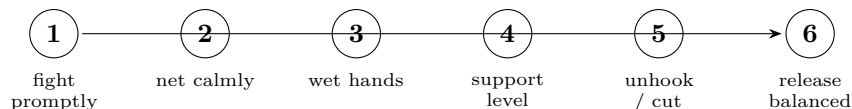
Handling & Release

ChatGPT edition

Prepare before the bite

Before casting

Match tackle to the largest plausible fish. Open pliers and cutters; wet and stage a knotless rubber net; decide whether the fish can be released beside the boat. Favor tackle that limits deep hooking when release is likely.



At the fish

1. Keep it in water when possible. Wet hands; never squeeze gills or eyes.
2. Support a large fish horizontally with two hands. Minimize air exposure; photograph only when tools and camera are already ready.
3. Back out an accessible hook. If deep extraction will prolong trauma, cut the line promptly; avoid stainless hooks where one may be left.
4. Return the fish when it maintains balance. Face it into gentle current only when present; do not pump it violently.

DEPTH AND TEMPERATURE

Deep capture and warm water increase risk. Wisconsin DNR does not recommend artificial swim-bladder deflation. Change location, depth, tackle or target rather than repeatedly producing fish unlikely to survive.

Source: Wisconsin DNR Catch-and-Release Guidelines.

Telos. Lake Country Fishing — Handling & Release. Revised 2026-07-26. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See LICENSE and CREDITS.md in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.

First Trip

A small, complete plan

ChatGPT edition

Before leaving

1. Confirm legal access, weather, exact-water 2026–27 rules, consumption advice and posted boating ordinances. Leave a float plan.
2. Pack fitted PFDs, water, sun/weather layers, charged waterproofed phone, first aid, pliers, cutters, knotless rubber net and AIS-cleaning supplies.
3. Rig one slip bobber and one simple jig or split-shot setup; carry a spare. Use legal bait from a lawful source.

A two-hour search

First 15 min	Observe wind, clarity, temperature, vegetation, traffic and bait.
Next 45 min	Fish one shallow edge. Change depth before changing everything.
Next 45 min	Test one break or saddle. Record bottom and contact depth.
Last 15 min	Photograph notes, clean/drain/remove, secure hooks and leave on time.

Beginner rule

One safe, repeatable presentation fished attentively teaches more than a box of constant changes. A bite is evidence; no bite is also evidence. Move only after you can state what depth, cover and speed you actually tested.

STOP CONDITIONS

Return early for thunder, rising wind, poor visibility, equipment trouble, cold stress, unsafe traffic or uncertainty about access or law. A small open boat is not lightning shelter. Wear the PFD.

Source basis: Wisconsin DNR Hook, Line & Thinker; boating safety; PFD; AIS and bait law; 2026–27 regulations; NOAA/NWS inland boating.

Telos. Lake Country Fishing — First Trip. Revised 2026-07-26. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See LICENSE and CREDITS.md in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.